Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Jeremiah

Jeremiah 1:1–19

Jeremiah's call is shown as a conversation. God spoke like a king to Jeremiah. Jeremiah's objections show he understood himself well. God answered his objections with promises and strong visions.

Jeremiah 1:2–3

Jehoahaz and Jehoiachin are not on this list of kings. Each ruled for less than three months.

Jeremiah 1:4–5

- In his first message from the Lord, Jeremiah learned three key truths about God:

1. God knows everything, including each person.
2. He can choose people for specific tasks even before they exist.
3. He gives his authority to those he calls.

- God chose Jeremiah for a special task and made him a prophet.
- Jeremiah's work reached many nations. Although he left the kingdom of Judah only three times, people worldwide have heard or read his writings (see Jeremiah 13:4–7; 43:7–8).

Jeremiah 1:6

Jeremiah was young (probably a teenager).

Jeremiah 1:7–8

God encouraged Jeremiah to focus on the importance of his task. He needed to meet God's standards for a royal messenger. This included being willing to travel and faithfully delivering God's messages.

Jeremiah 1:9

When God put his words in Jeremiah's mouth, he made Jeremiah an official royal messenger. God gave him the authority to speak publicly on his behalf.

Jeremiah 1:11–12

The Hebrew words for "almond tree" (shaqed) and "watching" (shoqed) sound very similar. God used this connection to teach Jeremiah something important. The almond tree blooms very early, before other trees, in January or February.

When God showed Jeremiah an almond tree, he was telling him that just as the almond tree is alert and ready to bloom early, God is always alert and watching over his people. We can see this same idea of God's constant watchful care in Psalm 121:3–8.

Jeremiah 1:13–14

Invading armies would bring terror to the people of Judah. Although Babylon was directly east of Judah, the desert between them forced the Babylonian army to attack Judah from the north. This invasion would be as destructive as rushing, boiling water

Jeremiah 1:17

Jeremiah feared looking foolish as the Lord's messenger (see Jeremiah Book Introduction, "Literary Features: The Messenger System"). However, refusing God's command would be truly foolish.

Jeremiah 1:18

A well-defended city could resist a siege for a long time, often until the attacking army left to handle another crisis in the empire.

Jeremiah 1:19

declares the Lord: This statement is as powerful as a royal order (see study note on Jeremiah 2:2).

Jeremiah 2:1–13

Jeremiah used marriage, infidelity, and divorce as images to show Judah's spiritual betrayal.

Jeremiah 2:2

- this is what the LORD says: Such statements were like an official seal or stamp of authority on a document. In many ancient Near Eastern royal messages, the ruler declared that the message was from him and had his authority.
- The image of Israel as a bride has been used since Hosea's time, about 760 to 722 BC (Hosea 2:2–19; see also Isaiah 54:6–8; 62:5). This idea is later applied to those living in heaven (Revelation 19:7; 21:2, 9).
- youth: after the exodus from Egypt, the Israelites symbolically married God when they agreed to a covenant relationship (Exodus 19:8; 24:7, 8; Deuteronomy 5:27; Ezekiel 16:8).
- devotion (Hebrew khesed): The Israelites pledged loyalty to the covenant Lord (see Deuteronomy 5:29).

Jeremiah 2:3

- Israel was holy because the Lord chose her to be his special people and show his character (Exodus 19:5–6; Leviticus 19; 22:31–33).
- the firstfruits of His harvest: Mosaic law required people to give the first part of every harvest to

the Lord (Exodus 23:16, 19; 34:22, 26; Leviticus 2:12, 14; 23:10, 17, 20; Numbers 18:12; 28:26; Deuteronomy 18:4; 26:10; Zechariah 14:20). The people who made the covenant with God at Mount Sinai promised their full commitment to the one true God. In return, the Lord protected them and punished their enemies during their journey to Canaan.

Jeremiah 2:5

The Israelites worshiped worthless idols, so delusions controlled their lives.

Jeremiah 2:6

By not seeking the Lord, Israel's ancestors showed they had lost interest in their history. To them, the God of Israel was an illusion. They only cared about immediate pleasures.

Jeremiah 2:7

defiled...detestable: See Deuteronomy 4:25–28.

Jeremiah 2:8

The leaders taught the people about Baal instead of teaching them about the Lord.

Jeremiah 2:9

- Therefore often means the Lord was about to make a decision (for example, Jeremiah 5:14; 6:21).
- The Hebrew word translated bring a case can mean "strive" or "contend." It might also suggest combat, like a fight, a verbal argument, or a legal case in court. Because the nation's leaders (Jeremiah 2:8) did not guide the people to him, the Lord planned to present his case against them. He was creating a court where he would be both the plaintiff and the all-powerful Judge (Ezekiel 20:35, 36; Micah 6:2). Jeremiah served as a messenger, prosecutor, and advocate for the plaintiff.

Jeremiah 2:10

Kedar, an Arabic tribe that came from Ishmael, lived in the desert east of the Jordan River Valley (see Jeremiah 49:28–33; Isaiah 21:16).

Jeremiah 2:11

No pagan nation exchanged its gods for those of another nation. Even though pagan nations generally worshiped the same nature deities (using different names), each nation stayed loyal to its own gods. This highlights Israel's disloyalty.

Jeremiah 2:12

The heavens and the earth often serve as witnesses to human events (see Jeremiah 51:48; Deuteronomy 32:1, 43; 1 Chronicles 16:31; Psalm 96:11; Isaiah 1:2; 44:23; 49:13).

Jeremiah 2:13

- The Israelites made two unwise choices:

1. They left the Lord, their true source of life
2. Thet started worshipping false gods that could not help them

- A fountain of living (running) water that flows all year, even during droughts, is a rare treasure (Psalm 36:9; John 4:14).
- The cisterns the Israelites built after entering Canaan were holes in the ground lined with plaster. These simple tanks collected rainwater from roofs during wet weather and provided water during dry summers. The water could become stale and unsafe to drink, and the plaster often cracked, causing the water to leak out.

Jeremiah 2:14

The Israelites were freed from slavery in Egypt. However, in Jeremiah's time, they became slaves again due to their agreements with Egypt and Assyria (Jeremiah 2:18).

Jeremiah 2:14–22

This review of Israel's history highlights the foolishness, violence, arrogance, and hopelessness of abandoning the true God to worship false pagan gods.

Jeremiah 2:15

Jeremiah describes the Assyrians, who destroyed the northern kingdom (2 Kings 17:5–23; Nahum 2:11–12), as lions.

Jeremiah 2:16

- Another enemy, the Egyptians, invaded from the south to take advantage of the situation (Jeremiah 50:17; 2 Kings 23:29–37).
- Memphis and Tahpanhes, Egypt's major cities near the mouth of the Nile, were famous for their wealth.

Jeremiah 2:18

Israel's alliances with Egypt and agreements with Assyria (2 Kings 15:19–19:37) brought only sorrow, not benefits. Neither the Nile in Egypt nor the Euphrates in Assyria ever helped Israel (Isaiah 30:1–3; Hosea 5:13).

Jeremiah 2:19

The choice to leave the Lord led to more punishment and shame for Israel's people (Isaiah 3:9; Hosea 5:5).

Jeremiah 2:20–21

- long ago: Lessons from Israel's history about the Israelites' rescue from slavery in Egypt had little impact. The people of Israel refused to serve God (Exodus 19:8; 34:15; Leviticus 26:13; Deuteronomy 12:2; Joshua 24:16; Judges 10:16; Isaiah 57:5, 7).
- you lay down as a prostitute: This metaphor was fitting for the Israelites bowing to idols. Their defiant words matched their rebellious actions. They often worshiped fertility gods, hoping for good crops and green pastures. Their rituals were pointless because the Lord planted the Israelites in Canaan and creates life and fertility.

Jeremiah 2:22

The metaphor shifts from a planted vine to a dirty cloth that soap or lye cannot clean. No matter how hard the Israelites scrubbed, their guilt remained visible (compare Isaiah 1:18).

Jeremiah 2:23

The people denied being Baal worshipers (compare Jeremiah 2:25). Archaeologists have found small plaques depicting Asherah, a female goddess, and a male god resembling Baal. However, the inscriptions on these plaques bear the name of the Lord (Yahweh). Sometimes, Baal worship was disguised as worship of Israel's God.

Jeremiah 2:23–3.5

Israel did not act like a loyal wife. Instead, she acted like:

- A wild animal in heat (Jeremiah 2:23–25)
- A thief (Jeremiah 2:26–30)
- A prostitute (Jeremiah 2:31–3:5)

Jeremiah 2:25

The Israelites admitted to worshipping Baal, which they had previously denied (Jeremiah 2:23), showing their true feelings.

Jeremiah 2:26

Israel's leaders did not feel ashamed for their wrongdoings. Any regret they showed during God's punishment came from selfishness, not true repentance (Psalm 78:34–37).

Jeremiah 2:27

- These idols of a father and mother likely represented Baal and Asherah.
- in the time of trouble, they say: See, for example, Judges 10:10; Isaiah 26:16; Hosea 5:15.

Jeremiah 2:28

- The Israelites unwisely worshipped many gods (Jeremiah 11:13; Deuteronomy 32:37; Judges 10:14; 2 Kings 17:30–31), who could not help them.
- Jeremiah spoke to the tribe of Judah, the people standing before him.

Jeremiah 2:30

devoured your prophets: See Jeremiah 26:20–23.

Jeremiah 2:31

The Lord's anger became a plea. He asked why the Israelites saw life in obedience to him as a barren wasteland of death and lack (Numbers 21:5), filled with evil and the fear of darkness (Job 24:17; 1 John 1:5–6).

Jeremiah 2:32

For centuries, the Israelites had forgotten the Lord, who was like their husband (Jeremiah 13:25; Psalm 106:21; Hosea 8:14).

Jeremiah 2:33–34

The Israelites made plans with their "lovers" , their neighbor who had strong armies, by forming treaties for protection. God had already promised them protection. God saw this as an act of betrayal that tainted Israel's character. Like their pagan neighbors, Israel harmed its own innocent and poor people (Jeremiah 7:6; 2 Kings 21:16; 24:4).

Jeremiah 2:35

Israel's sinful state was clear in the people's arrogant response. They claimed innocence and said God was angry without reason. God replied to their denial by declaring He would punish them severely and not accept their refusal to admit wrongdoing (Proverbs 23:13; Malachi 2:17; 3:8; 1 John 1:8, 10).

Jeremiah 2:36

Judah, in its unfaithfulness to the Lord, chose unreliable allies. The leaders sought political help from neighbors like Egypt, which was as false a friend as Assyria had been a century earlier.

Jeremiah 3:1

The law forbade a man from remarrying a woman he had divorced if she married another man afterward (Deuteronomy 24:1–4). A woman with many lovers was even less likely to be accepted back.

Jeremiah 3:1–5

Adultery was a valid reason for divorce (Deuteronomy 24:1–2; Hosea 2:1–5; 9:1). Judah committed spiritual adultery, arrogantly assuming that God would not object (Ezekiel 16:26; Zechariah 1:3).

Jeremiah 3:2

As the Lord's bride (see Jeremiah 2:2), Israel was not supposed to worship other gods.

Jeremiah 3:3

The Lord did not approve of the people's shameless behavior. He had already caused a drought, and their sexual rituals could not stop it (Jeremiah 14:3–6; Leviticus 26:19; Zephaniah 3:5).

Jeremiah 3:4–5

Instead of confessing their sins, the people tried to hide them with sweet talk. However, God saw through their deception. They were right that he would not be angry forever (Psalm 103:9; Isaiah 57:16; Malachi 1:6), but he promised to show his wrath (Jeremiah 4:7).

Jeremiah 3:6–10

- The Lord had been calling the kingdom of Judah "Israel" (Jeremiah 2:1–3:5), highlighting their identity as His people. Now, the Lord differentiates between Israel, the northern kingdom that was destroyed (2 Kings 17), and the kingdom of Judah. The people of the southern kingdom did not learn from the northern kingdom's downfall, so they were destined to face the same fate.
- Josiah, who reigned from 640 to 609 BC, encouraged a return to traditional faith and practices in 621 BC (2 Chronicles 34:29–33).

Jeremiah 3:7–8

King Josiah's reforms did not impact many common people. Idol worship, popular in northern Israel, also persisted among Judah's farmers and shepherds. They did not learn from the northern tribes' fate and even exceeded their practice of adultery (see Ezekiel 16:47–48).

Jeremiah 3:8

divorce: See 2 Kings 17:23.

Jeremiah 3:9

defiled the land: Because Israel turned away from their faith, fertile fields stopped producing crops, and sheep did not graze on green grass (Isaiah 57:6).

Jeremiah 3:10

Like the northern tribes of Israel, the people of Judah did not see idol worship as immoral. They ignored the Lord's objections. The people did not truly repent; they only pretended under Josiah's authority (2 Chronicles 34:32). Their religion was full of deception (Jeremiah 12:2; Hosea 7:14).

Jeremiah 3:11–4.2

The Lord asked Israel to repent, return, and reconcile with him (contrast Jeremiah 2:1–3:10). Israel had sinned and faced punishment. Now, the people of Judah sinned even more openly than their northern relatives, ignoring the lesson the Lord taught Israel (Ezekiel 16:51–52). However, it was still not too late to repent and become the blessing to the nations (Jeremiah 4:1–2) that God intended them to be (Genesis 12:3).

Jeremiah 3:12

In this decree, the Lord invites the survivors of unfaithful Israel from a century ago to return home. God's unchanging character is merciful, and He wants to offer salvation and restoration (Jeremiah 12:15; 31:20; 33:26; 2 Kings 17:6; Psalm 86:15).

Jeremiah 3:13

acknowledge your guilt, that you have rebelled...and have not obeyed My voice: Through these three steps of repentance, people can show their willingness to receive the Lord's salvation and restoration (Leviticus 26:40; Deuteronomy 30:1–5).

Jeremiah 3:14

- Return: The Lord once spoke to all Israel like a husband to an unfaithful wife. Now, he calls Israel faithless children. The Lord will bring chosen exiles back to the promised land (Jeremiah 31:6, 32; Hosea 2:19–20; Romans 11:5).
- to Zion: This refers to Jerusalem in the land of Israel.

Jeremiah 3:15

If the people of Israel repented, the Lord wanted to give them more than just the land. He also promised

to provide leaders (shepherds) who would guide them with knowledge and understanding (Jeremiah 23:4, 31; Ezekiel 34:11; Acts 20:28; Ephesians 4:11).

Jeremiah 3:16

When Judah was devastated and Jerusalem was destroyed, the land was almost empty of people. But in the future, the land would be full of people again. The inhabitants would not focus on the past or need the Ark to remind them of God's presence (Jeremiah 23:3; Isaiah 49:19; 65:17).

Jeremiah 3:17

In the future, Jerusalem will be a global center of worship called The Throne of the Lord, and people from all nations will give up their rebellion (Jeremiah 7:24; Deuteronomy 29:19; Isaiah 60:9).

Jeremiah 3:18

Judah and Israel would join others traveling to Jerusalem. The Lord would kindly bring them back from exile and settle them in the Promised Land again (Jeremiah 31:8; Isaiah 11:13; Ezekiel 37:16–22; Hosea 1:11; Amos 9:15).

Jeremiah 3:19–20

But: this transitional word highlights the difference between what the Lord desired and the real situation. The Lord wanted to treat his people as his precious children, but he could not. The covenant marriage between God and his people was broken by the unfaithful wife. The Lord could not ignore this sin (Isaiah 48:8).

Jeremiah 3:21–4.2

The people, held captive in Assyria, claimed they had repented of their sins. However, their words were insincere, and the Lord rejected their plea. God told his people that if they truly wanted to return to him, they had to abandon the hilltop altars where they worshiped idols and remove all traces of idolatry from their religion.

Jeremiah 3:22

The Lord remembered his children. From deep within, he called them to return so he could heal them. He wanted to put aside his anger and show his love (Jeremiah 30:17; 33:6; Hosea 6:1; 14:4).

Jeremiah 3:22–24

- The Lord heard the heartfelt prayer of devotion, and the people confirmed their acceptance of the Lord as their God (Jeremiah 31:7; Psalms 38:18; 121:1–2).
- The people confessed to worshiping idols and participating in religious ceremonies. They admitted these actions were misguided (Jeremiah 11:13; 14:20; Hosea 9:10) and recognized that salvation comes only from the Lord. Their ancestors wasted their wealth by sacrificing animals and children to honor Baal.

Jeremiah 4:1

The Lord noticed that even though the people prayed beautifully, they did not plan to discard their idols or change their way of living (Jeremiah 15:19; Joel 2:12).

Jeremiah 4:2

As surely as the Lord lives: When offering a prayer of confession and making oaths, the right attitude shows truth, justice, and righteousness.

- Truth means that the thoughts and feelings of those praying match their words.
- Justice means living by the Lord's laws, as He will judge the earth.
- Righteousness means treating others according to the Lord's Spirit and His moral standards.

This prayer requires a deep change in people's inner lives and outer behavior (Genesis 22:18; Deuteronomy 10:20; Psalm 72:18; Isaiah 48:1; 1 Corinthians 1:31). If the Israelites returned to the Lord in this way, they would be blessed, and their influence would spread as a blessing to all nations. Their changed lives would lead people worldwide to join in praising God's name.

Jeremiah 4:3

Sinners need to recognize their wrong actions and change by admitting their mistakes and seeking forgiveness (Hosea 10:12; see also Matthew 13:1–9).

Jeremiah 4:3–18

These verses focus on the kingdom of Judah and its capital, Jerusalem, in God's courtroom. The Lord declared he would judge Jerusalem through the Babylonians.

Jeremiah 4:4

- To address their sin, the people needed to give up their pride and power, which were very important to them (Deuteronomy 10:16; 30:6; Amos 5:6; Mark 9:43; Romans 2:28; Colossians 2:11).

- Circumcise yourselves: Circumcision was a covenant sign of submission to God.

Jeremiah 4:5–6

God was unleashing a fierce army upon the people, like pouring boiling water (see Jeremiah 1:13–14; 8:14; 50:2; Joshua 10:20; Isaiah 62:10).

Jeremiah 4:7

The approaching Babylonian army was like a fierce and ruthless lion (see Jeremiah 2:15). With strength and brutality, it would destroy everything, leaving houses empty and in ruins (Jeremiah 25:9, 38; 50:17; 2 Kings 24:1; Isaiah 1:7; 6:11; Ezekiel 26:7–10; Daniel 7:4).

Jeremiah 4:8

The Israelites were in trouble with the Lord and needed to make things right with him. Forming an army or organizing guerrilla bands would be useless. Instead, Jeremiah urged the people to repent by mourning and weeping with sincere hearts (Isaiah 22:12). By using the pronoun us, the prophet seems to include himself in the need for repentance (see Jeremiah 10:24).

Jeremiah 4:9

The foreign invasion would reveal to Judah's leaders that they were not as invincible as they thought (Jeremiah 48:41; Isaiah 22:3–5).

Jeremiah 4:10

Jeremiah felt confused and offended because he and the people believed God had promised peace for Jerusalem. However, these promises were false prophecies (Jeremiah 6:14; 14:13; 23:16–17).

Jeremiah 4:11–12

The Lord's people would soon experience the intense wind and loud force of God's judgment (Jeremiah 13:24; Hosea 13:15).

Jeremiah 4:13

Like his fellow citizens, Jeremiah felt afraid when he heard that the invasion from the north had started (Deuteronomy 28:49; Isaiah 5:28; Lamentations 4:19; Hosea 8:1; Habakkuk 1:8).

Jeremiah 4:14–15

Jeremiah still hoped his people would purify their hearts, abandon their evil thoughts, and completely reject idolatry. Otherwise, they would face God's judgment (Jeremiah 4:1; 6:19; 13:27; 50:17; Proverbs 1:22; Isaiah 1:16; James 4:8).

Jeremiah 4:17–18

Foreign armies had already surrounded the capital city. The attack was coming because the people rebelled against the Lord.

Jeremiah 4:19–21

When Jeremiah heard trumpets and the battle cries of the invaders who brought destruction, he realized that his family and others he knew were being killed or left homeless. Jeremiah could not escape the effects of God's judgment, even though he was faithfully serving the Lord (Jeremiah 9:1, 19; 10:19–20; 20:9; 2 Kings 25:11; 2 Chronicles 36:20; Psalm 42:7; Isaiah 15:5; 16:11; 21:3; 22:4; Ezekiel 7:26).

Jeremiah 4:23–26

In Jeremiah's vision, the Lord's intense anger was more important than his creative love (Jeremiah 10:10; 12:4; Isaiah 5:25; 24:19; Ezekiel 38:20; Zephaniah 1:3). He was reversing the order of creation (see Genesis 1:2–3).

Jeremiah 4:28

At funerals in Hebrew society, people traditionally mourned and wore black (compare Isaiah 5:30; 50:3). The Lord had judged the people guilty and promised to keep his word (Jeremiah 5:10; 30:11, 24; Isaiah 5:30; 46:10–11).

Jeremiah 4:29

flees...enter...climb: Panic took hold of the people of Judah because of the war's horrors. Their arrogance and smug confidence vanished (see Jeremiah 6:23–24).

Jeremiah 4:30

Oddly, some people acted as if nothing serious was happening. They tried to ignore the enemy, but their future looked grim. The enemy would kill them (Jeremiah 22:20, 22; 2 Kings 9:30; Isaiah 22:13; Lamentations 1:2, 19; Ezekiel 23:9–10, 22, 40–42).

Jeremiah 4:31

The people in Jerusalem felt such intense anguish that Jeremiah compared their pain to a woman giving birth to her first child. Like these women, beautiful Jerusalem was desperate (Jeremiah 13:21; 23:23; 30:6; Isaiah 1:15; 42:14; Lamentations 1:17).

Jeremiah 5:1–2

A just person follows God's laws and treats others fairly. An honest person is reliable, truthful, and loyal to God. Jeremiah found neither justice nor honesty. Although some people were under oath, their claims of innocence were false. Their actions showed they had lied under oath (Genesis 4:2; 7:9; Genesis 18:23–32; Isaiah 48:1; Ezekiel 22:30; Titus 1:15–16).

Jeremiah 5:3

Even when war brought disaster, the people ignored God and refused to turn away from their sins (Isaiah 9:13).

Jeremiah 5:4–5

- Jeremiah looked for an economic reason for Jerusalem's rebellion. He discovered that the leaders, despite their advantages, were as rebellious as the uneducated poor.
- A wooden yoke was placed on a farm animal's neck. Chains attached it to a plow or another tool for fieldwork (compare Jeremiah 27:2–12; Psalm 2:3).

Jeremiah 5:6

The Babylonians would attack like a lion, a wolf, and a leopard. These fierce animals could destroy human life. The people's rebellion and sins were very serious to the Lord (Jeremiah 4:7; 30:14–15; Psalm 104:20; Ezekiel 22:27; Hosea 13:7; Habakkuk 1:8; Zephaniah 3:3).

Jeremiah 5:7–8

These verses list the evidence of sins the people committed, such as:

- rejecting the Lord
- worshiping pagan gods
- engaging in sexual misconduct (Jeremiah 7:9; 12:16; Numbers 25:1–3; Deuteronomy 32:21; Joshua 23:7; Zephaniah 1:5; Galatians 4:8)

Idolatry and adultery were closely linked in Israel because both broke an exclusive covenant.

Jeremiah 5:9

The Lord saw the people's sins as deserving punishment (Jeremiah 9:9; 13:27; 29:23; Ezekiel 22:11).

Jeremiah 5:10–13

The Lord issued a decree to destroy Judah's vineyards, likely symbolizing Judah itself (see Isaiah 5:1–7; 27:2–6). The people ignored the Lord. They did not belong to him as his children, and he could not ignore their betrayal through idol worship (Jeremiah 3:6; 4:27; 7:27).

Jeremiah 5:12–13

- Even with the enemy approaching from the north, the people believed nothing bad would happen to them (Jeremiah 14:13; Isaiah 47:8). They did not respect God's prophets (literally the prophets).
- Some interpreters end the people's quote with Jeremiah 5:12 and attribute 5:13 to the Lord. The term "for the wind" would then refer to false prophets.

Jeremiah 5:14–19

The approaching army was likely Babylon's, which attacked Jerusalem in 605 BC. The Lord summoned the Babylonians to deliver the promised punishment (see Deuteronomy 28:15–62).

Jeremiah 5:15

The Babylonian language was Semitic like Hebrew, but the Israelites could not understand it.

Jeremiah 5:16–17

The well-trained and well-equipped Babylonian army treated their victims cruelly and destroyed everything valuable in the lands they conquered (see Habakkuk 1:6–10).

Jeremiah 5:18–19

The Lord reassured Jeremiah that the destruction would not be complete. He prepared Jeremiah to answer those who questioned why the Lord would bring such harsh judgment.

Jeremiah 5:20–21

- in the house of Jacob: In the Old Testament, "Jacob" and "Israel" are often used interchangeably. They can refer to the patriarch or the nation.
- To be foolish means to act rashly and immorally, ignoring consequences.
- senseless: This literally means no heart. When "heart" is negative, it means a person or group does not want to do moral acts and rejects intelligent behavior that pleases God.
- The people's ears and eyes worked (see study note on Jeremiah 6:10), but they stubbornly ignored the true meaning of what they heard and saw (Isaiah 6:9; Ezekiel 12:2; Mark 8:18).

Jeremiah 5:22

People should respect the Lord for his power and fear the idea of him using it against them. If the powerful sea cannot cross the boundaries the Lord set, then the rebellion of small Jerusalem will surely fail.

Jeremiah 5:23–25

The people mistakenly believed they could manage without the Lord, who gave rain for their crops (Deuteronomy 11:14). This wrongdoing led them to miss out on wonderful blessings and good things (Jeremiah 3:3).

Jeremiah 5:26–28

In Jerusalem, some wicked men became wealthy by oppressing orphans and the poor (Jeremiah 7:6).

Jeremiah 5:29–31

The people's sins (Jeremiah 5:26–28) fully justified the Lord's punishment, but the religious leaders committed even more wrongs. The prophets lied and claimed these lies were prophecies from the Lord (Jeremiah 14:14; Ezekiel 13:6). The priests, who were supposed to serve the people, became tyrants and ruled harshly. Surprisingly, the people accepted their leaders' new roles, even though this left them unprepared for the disaster approaching them (Micah 2:11).

Jeremiah 6:1

- Jeremiah's parents lived in the Benjamin tribal area, a narrow strip of land running east to west a few miles north of Jerusalem. Amos lived in Tekoa, about twelve miles south of Jerusalem (Amos 1:1).
- Beth-hakkerem was about three miles south of Jerusalem, overlooking Bethlehem.

Jeremiah 6:1–9

The invasion from the north, likely by the Babylonians in 605 BC, was approaching the kingdom of Judah. As the Lord's messenger, Jeremiah had the duty to warn the people so they could find shelter.

Jeremiah 6:2–5

Jeremiah described the commanding officers of the invading army as shepherds leading their soldiers to camp around the city. The initial plan was to strike the city walls at noon, when the attackers could see their work. However, the people in the city were so weakened that a night attack was just as effective (see 2 Kings 25:1–4).

Jeremiah 6:6–7

The Lord directed the Babylonians' attack. He told them to make battering rams to break through the walls and to build dirt ramps for easy access (Jeremiah 32:24).

Jeremiah 6:8

Even at this late hour, the Lord accused the people to make them listen and return to him.

Jeremiah 6:9

There was little time left for people to return to the one true God. The invasion survivors would be like leftover grapes on vines. God, the harvester, would find the survivors to ensure everyone in Israel faced this punishment.

Jeremiah 6:10

The people could hear because their replies were full of scorn, but they did not take the Lord's message seriously (see Acts 7:51).

Jeremiah 6:10–15

Jeremiah, the messenger and prosecutor, used rhetorical questions to show his love for the people. He was shocked when they responded with scorn. After showing evidence of sins by all levels of society, the prophet delivered a divine decree. The use of future tense in his indictment suggests he spoke before the invasion.

Jeremiah 6:11–12

Jeremiah felt the Lord's anger toward the people and could not hold back his emotions.

Jeremiah 6:13

The people were so driven by greed that they sought profit through violence (see Proverbs 1:11–19; also Isaiah 56:11; Micah 3:5, 11). The religious leaders were dishonest; they did not act according to their roles.

Jeremiah 6:14

The sinful behavior of God's people led to a serious problem that justified God's judgment. Instead of urging repentance, the religious leaders falsely promised peace (Jeremiah 23:17; Ezekiel 13:10).

Jeremiah 6:16

Following God's ancient laws (Malachi 4:4) would bring peace to people's souls (compare Matthew 11:29).

Jeremiah 6:16–21

The Lord urged the people to repent and warned them about the terrible consequences if they did not.

Jeremiah 6:17

Prophets served as the Lord's watchmen (Jeremiah 25:4; Isaiah 58:1; Ezekiel 3:17).

Jeremiah 6:18–19

All the nations would know that disaster had come to the Lord's people because they rejected his word (Jeremiah 19:3; Proverbs 1:31; Isaiah 1:2).

Jeremiah 6:20

The Lord found the offerings of expensive frankincense and fragrant perfumes offensive because of the people's rebellion (Jeremiah 7:21–23; Exodus 30:23; Psalms 40:6; 50:7–9; Isaiah 1:11; 43:24; 66:3; Amos 5:21; Micah 6:6–7).

Jeremiah 6:22–23

- The Lord reminded the people that the coming invasion was real. The soldiers had actual bows and spears (Isaiah 13:18).
- roars like the sea: The noise from thousands of soldiers with horses and chariots must have been terrifying (Isaiah 5:27–30).

Jeremiah 6:22–30

This conversation between Jeremiah and the Lord likely occurred at the start of the Babylonian invasion in 605 BC. In these three poems, Jeremiah shares the Lord's message (Jeremiah 6:22–23), connects with his people's fear, and urges them to repent quickly (6:24–26). He then receives a heartfelt message from the Lord (Jeremiah 6:27–30).

Jeremiah 6:26

Jeremiah told the people to wear burlap and sit in ashes to show regret for their sins and ask for God's mercy (Isaiah 58:5; Amos 8:10; Jonah 3:6; Micah 1:10).

Jeremiah 6:27

Jeremiah's job as a prophet conflicted with his empathy for his people. Like a metalworker, he had to apply criticism to test their quality against God's standards.

Jeremiah 6:27–30

The Lord stopped Jeremiah's lament and reminded him of his mission. God compared the prophet to a silversmith working with raw ore. The refining process would show that the silver content was too small to be valuable.

Jeremiah 6:28

The people's impurities were spiritual. They included rebelling against God, slandering others, being stubborn, and leading others into corruption (Ezekiel 22:18).

Jeremiah 6:29

To reveal their evil, God increased the intensity of his judgment. However, no precious silver emerged; only the impurities of wickedness remained (Zechariah 13:9; Malachi 3:3).

Jeremiah 6:30

The people, like rejected silver, must be discarded (Isaiah 1:22).

Jeremiah 7:1–2

The people were likely at the entrance of the Lord's Temple for an annual festival (see also Jeremiah 17:19; 26:2).

Jeremiah 7:1–15

Jeremiah corrected the people who believed that God's Temple would ensure their safety (compare Jeremiah 26:1–6).

Jeremiah 7:3–4

Pagans believed a symbol was the same as what it represented. In Jeremiah's time, people thought the temple was God's heavenly house. They found it absurd to think enemies could destroy it. To support this belief, they repeatedly chanted, This is the temple of the LORD. However, the Lord of Hosts did not need an earthly house (2 Samuel 7:6–7; 1 Kings 8:27). The Israelites' security from the Temple came from the Lord himself, and only on his terms (1 Kings 6:12).

Jeremiah 7:5–7

Idol worship harmed the people in several ways. Spiritually, idols were illusions. Socially, idol worship ruined their community bonds. Politically, it made them overconfident against foreign armies. Without change, they had no future in the Promised Land (Exodus 22:21–24; Deuteronomy 4:40; 6:14–15).

Jeremiah 7:8–10

- steal and murder, commit adultery and perjury: The people's actions broke most of the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:3–7, 13–17).
- burn incense…follow: Israel's relationship with God did not rely on any magical or ritual connection. It

depended on following the terms of his covenant. Their actions broke that relationship and disrespected the Lord's holy character.

Jeremiah 7:11

a den of robbers: See Jeremiah 5:29231; Matthew 21:13; Mark 11:17; Luke 19:46.

Jeremiah 7:12

Shiloh was a hill located between Shechem and Jerusalem. After Joshua led the conquest of Canaan, the Israelites set up the Tabernacle there (Joshua 18:1, 6–19; Judges 18:31). It served as the center of worship for the Israelite tribes until the Philistine army destroyed Shiloh around 1045 BC (see Jeremiah 26:6; Psalm 78:60).

Jeremiah 7:12–15

God allowed the Philistines to capture the Ark of the Covenant and destroy the Tabernacle at Shiloh. The people had tried to use the Ark as a magical object (1 Samuel 4:1–11). Similarly, he would allow the Babylonians to destroy the Temple.

Jeremiah 7:13–15

The people of the northern kingdom had acted like Judah was acting now. God sent many prophets to speak to them (2 Kings 17:22–23; 2 Chronicles 36:15–16), but they did not listen or respond. The Lord spared Jerusalem and the Temple when the Assyrians exiled the northern tribes in 722 BC. This time, the Temple would be destroyed.

Jeremiah 7:16

The Lord told Jeremiah not to pray for these people because it would not help (Jeremiah 15:1; compare Exodus 32:10; Deuteronomy 9:14).

Jeremiah 7:17–18

Pagan worship became a family activity. Each family member contributed to the ritual. They worshipped Ashtoreth, the Queen of Heaven, the mother goddess of the Canaanites, along with her family of deities (see Jeremiah 44:17–19).

Jeremiah 7:19

God's law benefits people. Those who do not follow his instructions harm themselves (compare Mark 2:27).

Jeremiah 7:20–23

The people's offerings and sacrifices meant nothing to the Lord if they were disobedient. Their sacrifices could not force God to act against His will. Instead, these offerings showed the people's trust in God's forgiveness. When people tried to use sacrifices to manipulate God while living selfishly, it only angered Him (Isaiah 1:10216; Amos 5:21–27). Obeying God allows for a personal relationship with Him, which is the foundation for a bright future (Hosea 6:6).

Jeremiah 7:24–26

Throughout their history, the Israelites ignored the messages from the Lord's prophets (2 Chronicles 36:15; Mark 12:1015010).

Jeremiah 7:27–29

The Lord told Jeremiah to keep sharing his messages, even though the people of Judah had completely rejected the Lord and would not listen (compare Ezekiel 2:7). Jeremiah should shave his head, mourn, and weep alone on the mountains (compare Job 1:20).

Jeremiah 7:30–34

The valley of Ben-Hinnom started on the west side of Jerusalem and continued around the south side. This narrow, steep valley opened into the Kidron Valley and served as the city's garbage dump and graveyard. The bodies of the poor, whether murdered or dead from disease, were dumped there. Child sacrifice, a practice completely abhorrent to the Lord (see 2 Chronicles 28:3; 33:6), also took place there. The valley was known as Topheth (2 Kings 23:10; Isaiah 30:33), possibly referring to ritual drums (Hebrew top) or sacrificial fires (tap) used there.

In the New Testament, it is called Gehenna, and Jesus compared hell to the fire that burned continuously in that valley (see study note on Matthew 5:29). Soon, it would be known as the Valley of Slaughter because the siege and destruction of Jerusalem, which lasted from 588 to 586 BC, would fill the valley with the bodies of the slain.

Jeremiah 7:30–8.3

This message announced death for the people of Judah. It came true with the destruction of Jerusalem in 586 BC.

Jeremiah 8:1–2

Scattering the bones of the dead showed the greatest disrespect to a defeated nation. Jerusalem's favorite

pagan gods—the sun, moon, and stars—could not stop it.

Jeremiah 8:4–7

These verses list the evidence of Judah's sins. The people engaged in ritual sex related to idol worship. They followed idol worship practices. They stayed in their delusions because lies trapped their minds and hearts. The term "lies" often refers to idols (Jeremiah 5:3, 6; 7:24; 9:6; Proverbs 24:16; Isaiah 44:20; Amos 5:2; Micah 7:8).

Jeremiah 8:4–17

These three short poems were likely shared during the reign of Jehoiakim.

Jeremiah 8:6

The Lord, who can hear everything (compare Luke 12:3), heard the people even when they spoke in private. Their words did not match reality, and no one felt sorry for doing wrong. Like a horse charging into battle without thinking of death or danger, they did not consider the consequences of their sins.

Jeremiah 8:7

stork…turtledove…swift…thrush: The Creator gave these birds the ability to navigate the sky from summer nesting places to winter feeding grounds, and they always follow those instincts precisely. In contrast, the people of Israel ignored God's revelations and the covenant laws he had established.

Jeremiah 8:8

The teachers, highly valued by the government and the Temple, included priests and non-priestly Levites. They were experts in explaining the Sinai covenant and were honored for their knowledge of covenant doctrine and legal details. Now, they were promoting the pagan views of King Jehoiakim and his officials as if they were new words from the Lord (compare study note on Jeremiah 2:23). The Lord called these new teachings lies.

Jeremiah 8:8–13

The people protested God's judgment because they had the word of the Lord. God condemned them because they did not follow his word (see Matthew 7:26; James 1:22–25).

Jeremiah 8:9–10

The phrase the wise is sarcastic. The Lord called their teachings foolish and revealed their greed (see Job 28:28). This sin controlled the prophets and priests, making them all frauds.

Jeremiah 8:10–12

These verses repeat Jeremiah 6:13–15 from earlier.

Jeremiah 8:13

- After presenting the evidence (see study note on Jeremiah 8:4–7), the Lord decreed the punishment for the elite sinners. They would be destroyed, along with the land's produce.
- declares the LORD: The Lord emphasized his authority behind his decree.

Jeremiah 8:14–15

The people heard Jeremiah announce the Lord's decree. They realized they deserved punishment for sinning against the Lord. Even though their fate was decided, they did not ask for forgiveness.

Jeremiah 8:16

See Jeremiah 6:22–23.

Jeremiah 8:18–9.26

The priests in the Temple memorized and repeated prayers as part of their rituals. They believed using the exact words was crucial; otherwise, the prayers lost their magical power. The character of the priests saying the prayers was not very important. This was also true for lamentations. In contrast, Jeremiah's prayers and lamentations were spontaneous and deeply personal.

Jeremiah 8:20

Instead of admitting their wrongdoing, the people gave in to hopelessness. The time for their salvation had passed, and they were not saved.

Jeremiah 8:21–22

Jeremiah felt the pain of his people. The close relationship between the Lord and his prophet means that sometimes "I" or "me" can refer to the Lord too. The Lord also feels the pain of his people (compare Matthew 23:37).

Jeremiah 8:22

- The balm in Gilead was a sticky sap from cuts in small evergreen trees in the highlands east of the Jordan River. Merchants sold this resin, claiming it had healing powers.

- Jeremiah noticed the people's need for God to heal their deep spiritual sickness. The people only saw the physical signs of God's judgment and refused to admit their spiritual rebellion caused their problems. The African-American spiritual "There Is a Balm in Gilead" identifies Jesus as the ultimate balm for our souls.

Jeremiah 9:2

Jeremiah wanted to escape and build a shack in the desert to forget the war (Psalm 55:6–8). He knew his people were unfaithful and dishonest, deserving punishment, but he did not want to be in Jerusalem to see it.

Jeremiah 9:3

- The Lord did not scold Jeremiah for his outburst. Instead, the Lord listed the charges against his people.
- The comparison with bows shows that the people's lies were meant to harm others.

Jeremiah 9:3–16

The heavenly court was still in session (see study note on Jeremiah 2:9). The divine Judge explained the charges against the people and justified the harsh verdict. Jeremiah interrupted the Lord's speech twice to respond to the Lord's messages (Jeremiah 9:10, 12).

Jeremiah 9:4–6

- Idolatry was the foundation of a culture built on lies.
- The word brother, used as a synonym for neighbor, shows that even close relationships were tainted by deceit.

Jeremiah 9:7–9

The Lord declared he would test the people through hardship (Jeremiah 6:27–30; Isaiah 1:25). Three rhetorical questions challenged Jeremiah or anyone else to propose an alternative to the Lord's actions or explain why they were unjustified.

Jeremiah 9:10

We do not know if the Lord or Jeremiah spoke these words. If the Lord spoke them, they show he gave judgment with a broken heart. If Jeremiah spoke them, they reveal his deep pain as he delivered the Lord's message. The prophet struggled to separate his love and compassion for the people from his role as the Lord's messenger.

Jeremiah 9:11

The Lord spoke these words clearly, balancing the deep emotion of Jeremiah 9:10 with another statement of judgment.

Jeremiah 9:12

It is unclear who asks these three questions. It could be the people or Jeremiah. The first two questions show frustration because the Lord's message about the religious and political situation seemed confusing. The Lord's words appeared too harsh and extreme. The third question shows anger about the land being desolated. The questioner seems to ask where to find the Lord's wisdom and goodness in these events.

Jeremiah 9:13–14

The Lord answered the questions (Jeremiah 9:12) by repeating his earlier words. The people caused the destruction of the city, towns, and land. They rejected the Lord's covenant instructions and deliberately disobeyed his commands. They became devoted idol worshipers because their ancestors taught them to worship images of Baal, the Canaanite god of storms and fertility.

Jeremiah 9:15–16

the LORD of Hosts, the God of Israel issued another decree. He would bring bitterness and poison through exile and widespread death in foreign lands.

Jeremiah 9:17

The Lord instructed the people to gather the professional mourners. These individuals often performed at funerals in the ancient Near East (see Amos 5:16; Mark 5:38).

Jeremiah 9:17–26

This series includes four short poems and a brief prose passage. They are messages from the Lord, likely delivered to the people of Judah by Jeremiah. Three poems describe the effects of the Lord's judgment on the people. The fourth poem offers encouragement. The prose section predicts doom for Judah and its neighboring nations.

Jeremiah 9:18–19

The mourners began their work right away. They mourned those who had died and grieved for Jerusalem, which faced destruction. They joined the people of Jerusalem who had lost their homes and had to flee as refugees.

Jeremiah 9:20–21

Due to many deaths in the city, there were not enough professional mourners. Women were encouraged to quickly teach their daughters how to mourn skillfully.

Jeremiah 9:23

Intellectuals might brag about their knowledge. The king and his royal court might show off their power with grand ceremonies. Wealthy merchants might display their wealth by wearing fancy clothes and building impressive structures. All of these will be destroyed during God's judgment.

Jeremiah 9:23–24

This short poem explores what true wisdom is.

Jeremiah 9:24

- The Lord values only one type of boast—the testimony of those who truly know and understand that He is the one true God (1 Corinthians 1:31; 2 Corinthians 10:17).
- loving devotion: This important covenant term (Hebrew khesed) means passionate loyalty. It is often undeserved and can be translated as "mercy," "grace," "kindness," or love. It is the Old Testament equivalent of the New Testament statement that "God is love" (1 John 4:8).
- righteousness: God interacts with His people on an ethical, moral level. He does what is right in every situation.
- I delight in these things: God does not enjoy judging and punishing sinners. Instead, He actively seeks to save them.

Jeremiah 9:25

- Because arrogance and sin controlled the nation, the Lord would soon announce a punishment.
- The Hebrew practice of circumcision began with Abraham (Genesis 17:10–14). Over time, this ritual became so linked with being God's chosen people that the Israelites believed it ensured a lasting bond with the Lord. However, physical circumcision is not enough; a person must also be spiritually circumcised—fully turning away from idol worship and dedicating themselves to making the Lord the focus of their life and actions (Romans 2:25–29).

Jeremiah 9:26

The Egyptians lived southwest, on both sides of the Nile River. The Edomites lived south and southeast of Judah. The Ammonites lived east of the Jordan River. The Moabites lived east of the Dead Sea. These nations practiced circumcision, but their hearts were not circumcised (they did not follow their beliefs sincerely) because they worshiped many false gods.

Jeremiah 10:1

As usual, Jeremiah identified the source of his message. He urged his audience not just to hear, but to pay close attention to the word of the Lord. In Hebrew thought, a person who does not respond has not truly heard.

Jeremiah 10:1–16

This poetic passage criticizes idol worship and affirms the unity and majesty of the one true God. It is not a logical discussion of divinity in nature or a detailed statement about God's attributes. Instead, it is a poem about the foolishness of worshiping idols that the worshipers have made. It includes strong affirmations of faith that clearly declare who God is.

Jeremiah 10:1–25

This poetic passage has three parts:

1. A contrast between the Lord and pagan idols (Jeremiah 10:1–16)
2. A reflection on the destruction awaiting idol worshipers (Jeremiah 10:17–18, 19–22)
3. A prayer asking God to act with restraint in the coming judgment and to ensure the pagan nations do not go unpunished (Jeremiah 10:23–25).

Jeremiah 10:2

The Lord instructed Israel, especially Judah, to behave differently from other nations. He warned them to avoid people like astrologers who claim to predict the future using stars.

Jeremiah 10:3

- The stars cannot predict anything; only the Lord knows the future.
- A craftsman carved a wooden idol from a tree until it resembled a creature on earth (Isaiah 40:18–20; 44:9–20).

Jeremiah 10:4

The carved image had no beauty or value by itself. People had to add gold and silver to make it impressive (see Jeremiah 10:9). Similarly, the image could not stand on its own. It needed to be secured to a foundation with a hammer and nails.

Jeremiah 10:5

Scarecrows in a garden only scare birds that do not know better. Similarly, idols are feared only by people who do not know better.

Jeremiah 10:6

There is none like You: See Isaiah 40:21–31; 44:5–8.

Jeremiah 10:7

- The fear of the Lord is not about being scared, but about deep respect and following his guidance (Job 28:28; Psalm 34:11–14; Proverbs 1:7). This leads to happiness (Proverbs 10:23).
- King of nations: God is not just the Lord of one small nation; he rules the whole world. Jeremiah noted that no human-made god could claim that title, and even wise people do not deserve such respect.

Jeremiah 10:9

The people who made idols had to get metal from far away. They bought silver from Tarshish in southern Spain. They purchased gold from Uphaz (or Ophir) in Arabia. Skilled craftsmen and expert tailors worked hard to turn a worthless piece of wood or stone into an attractive artifact (see Jeremiah 10:4–5).

Jeremiah 10:10

Pagan gods are not alive or permanent. People can destroy them or place them in museums. Stories about these idols often show them behaving immorally. This is because the creators of these stories wanted to justify their own immoral actions. The true God is holy, just, and opposes immoral behavior.

Jeremiah 10:11

- The pagan gods were not there when the heavens and earth were created, and they are not eternal.
- The original text of this verse is in Aramaic. This might suggest it quotes an Aramaic saying and was directed at the exiles in Babylon, where people spoke Aramaic.

Jeremiah 10:12

Jeremiah said that the Lord uses power, wisdom, and understanding to create and sustain the world.

Jeremiah 10:12–16

This stanza strongly affirms God's nature.

Jeremiah 10:13

This statement challenged the core of Baal, the Canaanite god of storm and fertility. The Canaanites believed Baal was the thunder and rain. However, the Lord claimed them as his creations (Psalm 135:5–7), through which he could speak and even roar (Job 37:2–5).

Jeremiah 10:16

the Portion of Jacob: This Hebrew expression means God provides everything the people need. The God of Israel is unique and not like pagan gods. As the Creator, God chose the people of Israel, rescued them from Egypt, and brought them into Canaan. The Lord freed them from slavery to make them his chosen people.

Jeremiah 10:17–18

- This brief decree about the upcoming exile is likely related to the first Babylonian invasion of Judah in 605 BC (see study note on Daniel 1:1). However, it might also refer to the invasions in 597, 586, or 581 BC, when some people of Judah were exiled (see Jeremiah 52:28–30).
- I will sling out: This phrase may include refugees who fled to nearby countries and those taken to Babylon.

Jeremiah 10:17–22

A judgment announcement (Jeremiah 10:17–18) is followed by a lament about its impact (10:19–22).

Jeremiah 10:19

Jeremiah experienced personal loss with his people. He spoke for both the nation and himself.

Jeremiah 10:20

Jeremiah's cherished hometown, Anathoth, was destroyed, and even the children were taken away. This happened to the whole nation.

Jeremiah 10:21

The shepherds, meaning the priests and prophets (see Jeremiah 5:29–31), ignored the wisdom from the Lord. This wisdom was kept in priestly memory and prophetic messages, both spoken and written. The divine decree foretold these leaders' complete failure and the scattering of the people as a result.

Jeremiah 10:22

The invading armies destroyed every town, leaving only rubble. Jackals (wild dogs) made their homes in the ruins.

Jeremiah 10:23–25

Jeremiah asked the Lord to unleash His anger not only on Judah but also on the nations that destroyed Israel. See Isaiah 26:9–11 and Habakkuk 1:17. These other kingdoms were so brutal that they turned the countryside into a barren wasteland. Jeremiah 10:25 quotes Psalm 79:6–7.

Jeremiah 11:1–3

The Lord gave Jeremiah permission to present legal charges against the people of Judah and Jerusalem. With the divine name's power supporting his words, the Lord explained the covenant's terms. These terms included curses for those who did not obey (see Deuteronomy 27:15–26; 28:15–68).

Jeremiah 11:1–17

The Lord reminded Jeremiah of several messages (Exodus 19:5) that had formed the foundation of the relationship between the Lord and Israel for many centuries. Since the kingdom of Judah was the last part of Israel, its people were the ones facing judgment before the Lord. This likely happened during King Jehoiakim's reign.

Jeremiah 11:4

The Egyptians knew how to smelt iron. However, the iron-smelting furnace of Egypt symbolized the Israelites' slavery there. The Lord rescued them from this slavery. God also promised to be their unique God if they would be his unique people (Exodus 6:7).

Jeremiah 11:5

- The Lord wanted to give Israel prosperity and blessings. Milk suggests cattle, sheep, and goats. Honey, produced by bees, suggests many different flowering and fruit-bearing plants.
- The word Amen is a Hebrew term that means "may it be so." The New Living Translation includes both the Hebrew word and its translation.

Jeremiah 11:6–7

Jeremiah used every way possible to spread the Lord's message to as many people as he could. As he visited each town and walked the streets of Jerusalem, he reminded the people to remember and obey the rules of the ancient covenant.

Jeremiah 11:8

The Old Testament books of Numbers, Judges, Samuel, and Kings tell how the people of Israel often broke the covenant until Jeremiah's time.

Jeremiah 11:9–10

- conspiracy: The word suggests "betrayal" or "treason" (compare 2 Kings 11:14).
- Judah and Jerusalem would stop worshiping the Redeemer God and start worshiping other gods. Both Israel (likely referring to the ten northern tribes) and Judah had broken the covenant.

Jeremiah 11:11

The Lord warned Jeremiah in advance about the decision He would make against the people. Disaster was coming, and prayers could not stop it. The time for God's mercy was over.

Jeremiah 11:12

The people of Judah and Jerusalem prayed and worshiped during their troubles, but not to the Lord. Instead, they prayed to their idols. They were attached to lifeless and powerless images made of wood and stone, instead of the one true God.

Jeremiah 11:13

Idolatry was widespread in Judah, with idols in every town and street.

Jeremiah 11:14

The Lord told Jeremiah not to cry or pray for the people of Jerusalem (see Jeremiah 7:16). The Lord would not listen to their prayers. Since the people were dedicated to worshiping Baal, any prayer they offered would be insincere.

Jeremiah 11:15

The people followed the words and ceremonies God required, but their worship was insincere. They did not love God or their neighbors.

Jeremiah 11:16–17

During the Exodus, the Lord saw Israel as a flourishing olive tree. King David compared himself to an olive tree (Psalm 52:8), and the apostle Paul used this image to explain how non-Jews could share in the blessings of salvation (Romans 11:16–21).

Jeremiah 11:18–19

The Lord warned Jeremiah during his commissioning (Jeremiah 1:19) that opposition would threaten his life. Jeremiah felt like a lamb led to slaughter, powerless to resist. This opposition happened before Jeremiah's trial in the Temple courtyard, early in Jehoiakim's reign (between 608 and 605 BC; see Jeremiah 26). Some scholars think this verse foreshadows Christ's death, similar to the suffering servant in Isaiah 53:7.

Jeremiah 11:18–23

The Lord warned Jeremiah about the plans against him. Jeremiah prayed, and the Lord promised to save him.

Jeremiah 11:20

Jeremiah wanted the Lord to punish his enemies because the Lord knew their deepest thoughts and secrets. As events unfolded, Jeremiah learned that the Lord had his own way of handling his enemies.

Jeremiah 11:21–23

Jeremiah's enemies included his family and relatives in his hometown of Anathoth, and he grieved over their fate (Jeremiah 10:20). They demanded that he stop prophesying in the Lord's name. In line with the Lord's promise to protect him (Jeremiah 1:19), the Lord told Jeremiah that even the families of his enemies, including their children, would lose their lives when their punishment came.

Jeremiah 12:1

Jeremiah agreed that the Lord was fair in past dealings with him. However, he was confused about why his life was in danger, despite his obedience. Meanwhile, wicked and evil people seemed to be prosperous and happy.

Jeremiah 12:1–4

Jeremiah questioned why a fair God did not quickly punish the wicked. He could not tolerate ongoing evil, but he also felt sorrow for the severe human suffering he foresaw (Jeremiah 10:19–25).

Jeremiah 12:2

Jeremiah was upset that the Lord let evil people succeed and find happiness.

Jeremiah 12:3

Jeremiah's words may seem self-righteous, but he was open to the Lord examining his heart. He was also angry and wanted his enemies to suffer the harm they planned for him. He hoped they would be killed like defenseless sheep. Jeremiah did not appear to want their forgiveness or their return to the Lord.

Jeremiah 12:4

Jeremiah felt helpless because the Lord's plan to destroy the land seemed too harsh. Jeremiah understood that the people were wrong to mockingly say the Lord could not predict the future (compare Isaiah 46:10).

Jeremiah 12:5

Jeremiah's conflict with his family and friends was like racing against men. This was nothing compared to racing against horses, which would happen when the foreign army arrived. The coming war would be as difficult as navigating the dense bushes near the Jordan River.

Jeremiah 12:5–13

The Lord corrected his messenger and answered his question by asking his own questions.

Jeremiah 12:6

Jeremiah's family was like a small version of Judah. They secretly cried aloud (plotted) against him (Jeremiah 11:9) while speaking kindly to him. They wanted to convince him that the Lord would protect Judah and Jerusalem from the Babylonians. They hoped to prevent him from bringing shame to the family (compare Mark 3:21).

Jeremiah 12:7–13

God referred to the people of Judah as his special possession, his dearest ones, his chosen people, and his vineyard. However, they became hostile to him, so they had to be given over to their enemies. The most severe justice they could face was for the Lord to withdraw and let them suffer the consequences of their evil actions.

Jeremiah 12:9

Large flocks of speckled vultures would prey on the people of Judah. Soon, wild animals would pick their bodies clean.

Jeremiah 12:10

A vineyard commonly symbolizes God's people, as seen in passages like Isaiah 5:1–10, Matthew 21:33–45, and John 15:1–8.

Jeremiah 12:10–13

The corrupt rulers of Judah had already ruined the land by leading the people into sin (for example, 2 Kings 16:8–19; 21:16; 23:33–35). The invading army would just finish the job.

Jeremiah 12:11

The Lord felt deep sorrow as he looked at the barren land. He had commanded the invasion based on the Sinai covenant's terms, but it brought him no joy. Sadly, only God cared.

Jeremiah 12:12

The invading armies were the sword sent by the Lord to destroy the land.

Jeremiah 12:13

The Lord felt no joy when invaders ate his people's crops, leaving only thorns. However, the people of Judah turned away from their faith, which deserved the Lord's fierce anger (see Ezekiel 16:36–39), leading to their shame.

Jeremiah 12:14

- No evil nation would escape God's punishment, not even those He used to punish Judah. He would remove them.
- The Lord would also uproot (remove) Judah, but this refers positively to freeing them from exile.

Jeremiah 12:14–17

The Lord explained an important part of Jeremiah's mission (see Jeremiah 1:10).

Jeremiah 12:15

I will…have compassion on them: Even other nations, no matter how wicked, can recover after facing disaster.

Jeremiah 12:16

To experience God's compassion (Jeremiah 12:15), people from other nations needed to stop worshiping idols and learn God's ways. This change required publicly accepting the Sinai covenant, which included saying, as surely as the Lord lives. They also needed to reject any promises made in Baal's name, which had led Israelites to worship foreign idols.

Jeremiah 12:17

- If these nations refused to obey the Lord, they would be removed and destroyed (Jeremiah 1:10).
- declares the LORD: This statement gave God's words the power of a divine command.

Jeremiah 13:1–2

God told Jeremiah to keep a linen loincloth unwashed to represent Judah's unrighteousness (compare Isaiah 64:5; Revelation 19:8). This garment is similar to modern-day underwear.

Jeremiah 13:1–14

The Lord instructed Jeremiah to perform a parable (see also Jeremiah 18, 19, 27; see "Prophetic Sign Acts" Theme Note). This parable combined actions with words to highlight key aspects of the Lord's response to Judah's rebellion. Jeremiah struggled to fully understand the severe consequences of rejecting the Lord's command for the people to worship him as the one true God. The direct relationship between Jeremiah and the Lord provided the basis for this event.

Jeremiah 13:3–5

The Euphrates River is 300 miles north of Jerusalem. Jeremiah likely joined a merchant caravan for safety during the 600-mile round trip. Although Jeremiah did not know why he was going, he followed God's instructions.

Jeremiah 13:6–7

- The safest time to travel was during the dry season, from June to September. Cloth was most likely to rot during the wet season, from October to May.
- Many days later was likely between six and ten months.

Jeremiah 13:8–9

The parable showed how terrible the pride of Judah and Jerusalem had become. It explained how God allowed the consequences of sin to happen.

Jeremiah 13:10–11

- The rotten loincloth symbolized the people of Judah and Israel. Their wicked rebellion had corrupted them and made them worthless.
- clings: The same Hebrew word can mean "joins" and describes marital faithfulness (Genesis 2:24).
- My people for My renown: See also Exodus 19:5, 6; Deuteronomy 32:10–12; Ephesians 2:7; 3:10.

Jeremiah 13:12–14

Don't we surely know: The people believed that the Lord would keep blessing them as he had before (Psalm 104:15; Proverbs 9:2–5). However, the wine was

not a symbol of blessing; here, drunkenness represented God's anger (compare Revelation 14:10).

Jeremiah 13:15–16

Jeremiah urged the people to listen and not be proud, but to change their attitude. If they refused to recognize the Lord as the one true God of Israel, a terrible darkness would come over the nation.

Jeremiah 13:17

Jeremiah learned that if the people did not recognize the Lord, they would be taken into exile. This idea made him very sad.

Jeremiah 13:18–19

The king was likely Jehoiakim's son, Jehoiachin, who became king in 597 BC after his father's death. His mother was Nehushta (see 2 Kings 24:1–9). Jehoiachin was eighteen years old and ruled for only three months. This message was probably given during his brief reign. The Babylonians would soon take his crowns (see 2 Kings 24:11–16). They would also seize the treasures of the Temple and palace. The royalty and elite of Judah would be taken into exile. Meanwhile, Judah's southern neighbors would capture the towns of the Negev, the desert area from Beersheba to the Gulf of Aqaba.

Jeremiah 13:20–22

King Jehoiachin did not care about the well-being of his people, the beautiful flock of Judah. Because of the king's many sins, Judah suffered abuse from its supposed allies.

Jeremiah 13:23

the Ethiopian: People cannot choose their skin color, just like a leopard cannot choose its spots. Similarly, God's people were born trapped by evil. They could not change by themselves and refused to let the Lord change them.

Jeremiah 13:24

I will scatter you like chaff: This image shows the exile of the people of Judah. Compare with Psalm 1:4–5.

Jeremiah 13:24–27

The divine Judge declared a guilty verdict.

Jeremiah 13:25

The people of Judah could not avoid their punishment. They had forgotten God and turned to false gods.

Jeremiah 13:26

God let the Babylonians take all of Judah's treasures and capture its people.

Jeremiah 13:27

Judah's idol worship involved ritual sex acts in the fields and on the hills. The Lord wanted his people to be spiritually and sexually pure in their relationship with him.

Jeremiah 14:1–22

This chapter is a conversation between the Lord, Jeremiah, and the people. It began because a severe drought affected the land.

Jeremiah 14:2–3

During a drought, no crops were sold in the markets at the Jerusalem gates. People could not store previous harvests for long, so starvation threatened them. Cisterns built to collect water dried up, and without rain, no water was available for drinking or cooking meals. As a result, a great cry rose from Jerusalem.

Jeremiah 14:4–6

- Both people and animals suffered during the drought.
- The farmers covered their heads with rough burlap to show shame, humiliation, and mourning.

Jeremiah 14:7–9

The people admitted their sins but did not change their bad behavior. They tried to trick God into helping them by doubting his love, wisdom, and power, while still claiming to be his chosen people.

Jeremiah 14:10

The Lord's response to their selfish prayer addressed the main issue. Their wickedness had ruined their status as God's people, making their prayer pointless. God's judgment would continue.

Jeremiah 14:11–12

For the third time (see Jeremiah 7:16; 11:14), God told Jeremiah not to pray for the people of Judah and Jerusalem. Fasting would be pointless because the Lord had decided to ignore them. The priests' burnt and grain offerings, which the Lord had given Moses as a way to worship him (see Leviticus 1–2), would be wasted because the Lord would not accept them. Instead, the Lord would respond with war, famine, and disease.

Jeremiah 14:13–16

the prophets: The government of Judah had a group of prophets who supported the king's religious views. The Lord often condemned these prophets, along with the officials and priests. Here, the Lord revealed them as impostors and described the consequences for them and the people they advised.

Jeremiah 14:17–18

As he looked at Judah's state, God clearly showed his sadness through a short poem. The Lord does not enjoy the death of the wicked (Ezekiel 18:23; 33:11).

Jeremiah 14:19–22

Even though the Lord commanded otherwise (Jeremiah 14:11), Jeremiah prayed for God to lessen the current disaster and the worse one ahead.

Jeremiah 14:22

Worshiping other gods is pointless. Only the Creator of the universe can control nature.

Jeremiah 15:1

Moses and Samuel were known for their intercessory prayer. Several times, when they prayed for the rebellious Israelites, the Lord withdrew his threatened punishment (see Exodus 32:11–14; Numbers 14:13–20; 1 Samuel 7:8–10). However, now even their intervention would not have worked.

Jeremiah 15:1–9

The Lord replied to Jeremiah's prayer (Jeremiah 14:19–22) that Judah's destruction could not be avoided.

Jeremiah 15:2

The people had nowhere to escape from death, war, famine, and captivity.

Jeremiah 15:4

Judah's turning away from faith began with Manasseh, son of Hezekiah. Manasseh was king from 697 to 642 BC (see 2 Kings 21:1–18; 2 Chronicles 33:1–20).

Jeremiah 15:5

These are rhetorical questions. The answer is "no one!"

Jeremiah 15:6–7

The people heard the accusation that they had abandoned God and turned away from him before (Jeremiah 2:13), but they did not take it seriously. Although the Lord often gave them another chance to repent, their sin provoked him to enforce the curses of the Sinai covenant (Deuteronomy 27:15–26).

Jeremiah 15:8–9

Both the old and young men would pass away.

Jeremiah 15:10

Jeremiah felt deep grief when people hated and cursed him without reason.

Jeremiah 15:10–21

Jeremiah shared his feelings with God about the unfair treatment he faced for delivering God's message. In response, God promised to protect and care for him.

Jeremiah 15:11

When the people faced trouble and distress, they asked Jeremiah to speak for them.

Jeremiah 15:11–14

The Lord answered Jeremiah's complaint with comfort and explained what would happen soon.

Jeremiah 15:12

Iron and bronze symbolize the strong will that the Lord would give to Jeremiah (Jeremiah 1:18).

Jeremiah 15:13–14

It is unclear if the Lord was speaking about Jeremiah's future or Judah's future. If about Jeremiah, this prediction came true after Jerusalem fell in 586 BC, when Jeremiah and Baruch were taken to Egypt against their will (see Jeremiah 41–44). If it refers to Judah's future, the prediction came true with the fall of Jerusalem and the Exile.

Jeremiah 15:15–18

Jeremiah's prayer reveals a key moment in his relationship with the Lord. Persecution had weakened him. Jeremiah might have started to think like the rebellious people of Judah.

Jeremiah 15:16–17

Jeremiah was happy to share God's word, even though it meant he could not join the joyful feasts of his sinful people. He complained about the unfairness he experienced (Jeremiah 15:18).

Jeremiah 15:18

Jeremiah asked two rhetorical questions that suggest he should not have to suffer.

Jeremiah 15:19

The Lord told Jeremiah he needed to make a decision. If Jeremiah chose to serve and submit, the Lord would make him useful again. If Jeremiah spoke words of submission, faith, and obedience, and rejected worthless words (like those of the false prophets, Jeremiah 14:14–16), he could continue as the Lord's spokesman.

Jeremiah 15:20–21

The Lord confirmed the promises he made to Jeremiah when he called him to be a prophet (see Jeremiah 1:18–19).

Jeremiah 16:1–2

In Hebrew society, bachelors were uncommon, and males were expected to marry in their early twenties. However, the severe crisis of the time required Jeremiah to serve as a divine messenger without family obligations. He needed to rely completely on the Lord (compare 1 Corinthians 7:26–35).

Jeremiah 16:1–18

Jeremiah's life served as a sign or parable (see "Prophetic Sign Acts" Theme Note). The Lord instructed him not to marry (Jeremiah 16:1–4), not to attend funerals (16:5–7) or celebrations (16:8–9).

Jeremiah 16:3–4

Jeremiah's lack of children served as a lesson about the future. Soon, many children and parents would die, leaving no one to mourn or bury them.

Jeremiah 16:5–7

The ban on funerals and mourning was a lesson for the people of Judah. The destruction would be so vast that no one could mourn properly or comfort others.

Jeremiah 16:8–9

The ban on attending feasts and parties isolated Jeremiah from meaningful social contact, but the Lord considered it important. Soon, the entire nation and its social interactions would end.

Jeremiah 16:10

The Lord told Jeremiah that people would question him. They would show self-righteousness and believe the Lord should not harm them.

Jeremiah 16:11–13

Jeremiah's response was the message he got when he was given his mission: The people left the Lord for idols (Jeremiah 2), so the Lord would leave them.

Jeremiah 16:14–15

The Lord planned to bring his people back from exile to the Promised Land. This event would be as significant as the exodus from Egypt (see Ezra 1–6). The Exodus was the main event in Israel's history that showed the reality and power of the one true God.

Jeremiah 16:14–18

Jeremiah's message had two parts:

1. Judgment does not remove future hope (Jeremiah 16:14–15)
2. Hope does not eliminate the certainty of judgment (Jeremiah 16:16–18).

Jeremiah 16:16

The fishermen and hunters were the Babylonian soldiers God used to carry out his judgment (see Habakkuk 1:14–16).

Jeremiah 16:18

The punishment was severe—slaughter and exile—because the people of Judah broke the two most important commandments. They did not love God (Deuteronomy 6:4–5), and they did not love their neighbors (Leviticus 19:18; see also Matthew 22:37–40).

Jeremiah 16:19–20

Jeremiah worshiped the Lord for protecting him during difficult times and providing salvation to people worldwide.

Jeremiah 16:21

The Lord wants everyone to know his power and strength. He wants them to understand that he is the Lord (see Exodus 6:7; 8:22).

Jeremiah 17:1

- A stone mason used an iron chisel or a diamond point to carve images and texts on stones permanently. Idol worship had so hardened the people's thoughts, emotions, and will that change seemed impossible.
- In Old Testament times, the corners of altars had projections called "horns" (for example, Exodus 27:1–2). According to covenant rules, when offering an

animal sacrifice, they applied blood to these horns. How Baal worshipers treated them is unknown.

Jeremiah 17:1–4

The families of Judah were devoted to Baal worship. The Lord listed their sins to justify their judgment.

Jeremiah 17:2

People cut Asherah poles from trees and placed them near altars for Baal, the Canaanite storm god. Asherah was the Canaanite goddess of fertility, representing the moist ground that helped crops grow. People performed ritual sex near these altars to encourage rain, seed sprouting, and plant growth. A tree near an altar could also symbolize this fertility goddess. The people of Judah were so morally corrupt that parents encouraged their children to join these rituals.

Jeremiah 17:3

The Lord's holy mountain was the Temple Mount in Jerusalem, where people stored wealth and treasures.

Jeremiah 17:4

The wonderful possession, the Promised Land, would be lost by Judah when the people were taken captive to Babylon.

Jeremiah 17:5

Trust is a mindset that leads to obedience (see Jeremiah 11:4; Deuteronomy 27:15–26).

Jeremiah 17:5–10

This meditation contrasts the foolishness of trusting in humans with the wisdom of trusting in the Lord.

Jeremiah 17:6

The people of Judah would be completely helpless during disasters because they trusted human abilities instead of the Lord. They would be like desert shrubs that are stunted due to a lack of water.

Jeremiah 17:7–8

- Those who trust in the Lord, like trees planted along a riverbank, will have plenty of resources and be ready for life's changes.
- Water symbolizes the law of the Lord (compare Psalm 1; Ezekiel 47:1–12; Revelation 2:1–2).

Jeremiah 17:9–10

By nature, the human heart can be deceitful and very wicked. Only the Lord truly understands its depth.

Jeremiah 17:11

Jeremiah mentioned a general principle (see Psalm 73) that was not always true (Job 21:27–33): People who gain wealth unfairly eventually lose it.

Jeremiah 17:11–13

Jeremiah praised the Lord's faithfulness to his people, unlike the fate of those who turned away from the Lord.

Jeremiah 17:11–18

Jeremiah said he learned this lesson and truly trusted in the Lord.

Jeremiah 17:12

God's loyal followers worship the all-powerful Lord, not money.

Jeremiah 17:14

Only the Lord can heal and save, so we should praise him alone.

Jeremiah 17:14–18

Jeremiah asked the Lord to rescue him from his enemies because he had been faithful. He also asked for healing, salvation, and justice.

Jeremiah 17:15

The people mocked Jeremiah because his predictions had not come true. They might have even called him a false prophet (see Deuteronomy 18:21–22).

Jeremiah 17:16

Jeremiah asked the Lord to prove his innocence because he was faithful.

Jeremiah 17:17

Jeremiah was naturally afraid of the upcoming national disaster, so he asked the Lord for protection.

Jeremiah 17:18

Jeremiah wanted those who persecuted him to feel the shame and dismay he felt (Jeremiah 17:15).

Jeremiah 17:19–20

The Lord told Jeremiah to go to each gate where people did business. He was to confront the wrongdoers directly, starting with the king.

Jeremiah 17:19–27

Driven by greed, the people of Jerusalem were disrespecting the Sabbath day (see Exodus 20:8–11; Deuteronomy 5:12–15). By observing the Sabbath, they would miss out on trade income. The Lord explained why they should keep the Sabbath holy.

Jeremiah 17:21–22

Trading on the Sabbath was wrong and needed to stop. The Sabbath was not for buying and selling. It was established in the Sinai covenant as a holy day (Exodus 29:8–11; 31:12–17). On this day, the people of Israel were to rest and honor the Lord.

Jeremiah 17:23

they...would not listen or receive My discipline: The people likely thought observing the Sabbath was too costly, so they ignored or overlooked its rules.

Jeremiah 17:24–25

- The Lord wanted to give the people a chance to change their behavior. By choosing to obey God, the people could enjoy lasting peace and the continuation of the kingdom and the city of Jerusalem.
- The promise of chariots and horses symbolized the Lord's blessing.

Jeremiah 17:26

- If the people repented, the Lord's blessings would reach the towns of Judah and Benjamin.
- The western foothills extended north and south between the coastal plain of the Mediterranean Sea and the hill country, where Jerusalem was located.
- The Negev was the desert that extended from Beersheba southward to the Gulf of Aqaba. People from all these areas would bring their offerings to worship the Lord in his Temple.

Jeremiah 17:27

I will kindle an unquenchable fire in its gates: This happened in 586 BC (2 Kings 25:9).

Jeremiah 18:1–4

Jeremiah watched the potter shape a clay jar. The potter then crushed it and began again.

Jeremiah 18:1–11

The Lord involved Jeremiah in a lesson using objects. What Jeremiah saw at the potter's shop symbolized what the Lord planned to do with Judah.

Jeremiah 18:5–6

The Lord compared himself to this potter. He could set high standards and decide to destroy or reshape his creations.

Jeremiah 18:7–10

If a nation or kingdom rejected the one true God, God could decide to uproot, tear down, and destroy it (see Jeremiah 1:10). If the nation changed its evil ways, the Lord's anger would ease, and he would not destroy it.

Jeremiah 18:11

The Lord intended to treat Judah and Jerusalem like a potter shapes clay (Jeremiah 18:4). However, they could avoid disaster by rejecting their evil ways and doing what is right.

Jeremiah 18:12

The people of Judah ignored the Lord's message. They mocked it, refused to change, and boldly followed their own wrong desires.

Jeremiah 18:13

Who has ever heard things like these?: In other nations, people did not abandon their national gods (Jeremiah 2:11–13), but Israel openly mocked the one true God.

Jeremiah 18:13–17

The Lord said he would scatter his people because they left him.

Jeremiah 18:14–15

- The answer to these two rhetorical questions was "No." The snow and streams of the mountaintops of Lebanon were always reliable. In contrast, the Lord's people were not reliable.
- The ancient highways represented a life of faithfulness to the covenant (Jeremiah 6:16), while the muddy paths symbolized a life of self-serving paganism.

Jeremiah 18:16–17

- The Lord declared judgment on Judah and Jerusalem.
- They have made their land a desolation...I will scatter them: Between 605 and 586 BC, Judah and Jerusalem gradually lost their residents.
- like the east wind: In the summer, a strong hot wind from the east can blow sand and dust from the desert into Judah.

- I will show them My back: The people would no longer have a covenant relationship with the Lord.

Jeremiah 18:18

The people disliked Jeremiah because his strong messages opposed their leaders' messages, so they planned to silence him.

Jeremiah 18:18–23

Jeremiah passionately asked for revenge against those trying to undermine his work.

Jeremiah 18:19–20

Jeremiah told the Lord about the unfairness of his enemies' actions against him.

Jeremiah 18:21–23

In his prayer for vengeance, Jeremiah asked God to carry out the promised curses on those who broke his covenant (compare Deuteronomy 27:11–26; 28:15–68; see also the "Prayers for Vengeance" Theme Note).

Jeremiah 19:1–15

Jeremiah performed another parable (see Jeremiah 13:1–14) to show Judah's leaders that the Lord would completely destroy their idolatrous and violent nation.

Jeremiah 19:4–5

- The have burned incense: In the Sinai covenant, only priests should offer incense when worshiping the Lord (Exodus 30:8). Offering incense to idols was a serious insult to the Lord.
- the blood of the innocent: Child sacrifice occurred in Baal worship and sometimes by the kings of Judah (2 Kings 17:17; Psalm 106:37–38).

Jeremiah 19:6

Valley of Slaughter: Compare Jeremiah 7:32.

Jeremiah 19:9

- The siege of Jerusalem lasted two and a half years. It caused severe famine and despair (see 2 Kings 25:1–4).
- their sons and daughters: Compare Deuteronomy 28:53–57.

Jeremiah 19:10–13

Judah, the nation these leaders represented, would be completely destroyed and beyond repair. Judah would never again be a sovereign nation with a king from David's line (see Jeremiah 33:17–18). The city of Jerusalem would become as defiled as Topheth, the unclean valley (see study note on Jeremiah 7:30–34).

Jeremiah 19:14–15

Jeremiah finished his message at the Temple of the Lord, where the ordinary people could hear him.

Jeremiah 20:1–2

Pashhur, the head of the police maintaining order in the Temple area, was second in authority to the high priest. He had heard Jeremiah announce the Lord's decree about the destruction of Jerusalem, including the Temple. He considered it such blasphemy that he believed Jeremiah should be punished.

Jeremiah 20:1–6

The persecution Jeremiah faced escalated from words to actions. He was whipped and put in stocks overnight for allegedly blaspheming the Temple. Upon his release, Jeremiah delivered a message of personal condemnation from the Lord to his jailer.

Jeremiah 20:3

Magor-missabib: In Hebrew, this means "surrounded by terror." Compare Jeremiah 46:5; Psalm 31:13.

Jeremiah 20:4–5

This is the first time Jeremiah names Babylon as the country whose armies will invade Judah and take the people into exile. The invaders will take the precious jewels, gold, and silver, leaving Judah without resources.

Jeremiah 20:6

Pashhur would face evidence showing he was a false prophet.

Jeremiah 20:7

you have deceived me: Jeremiah talked about his calling from the Lord (Jeremiah 1:5–10) using the same Hebrew word that in other places means sexual seduction (Exodus 22:16).

Jeremiah 20:8–9

Jeremiah could not stop speaking God's judgment, even though people mocked him for it (see also Job 32:18–20; Psalm 39:1–3; Acts 4:18–20).

Jeremiah 20:10

The people mockingly called Jeremiah by the name he had given to Pashhur, Terror is on every side (Jeremiah

20:3). Even Jeremiah's old friends tried to twist his words and trap him.

Jeremiah 20:11

Jeremiah realized that God was like a powerful warrior by his side. Jeremiah's enemies were at a disadvantage and would completely fail.

Jeremiah 20:12

Jeremiah fully trusted the Lord of Heaven's Armies (see Jeremiah 5:14), who could take revenge on the prophet's enemies.

Jeremiah 20:13

Suddenly, relief and joy filled Jeremiah's soul. He remembered that when he was poor and needy, the Lord had saved him from his oppressors.

Jeremiah 20:14–18

Jeremiah hoped for rescue, but he still faced harsh realities. Surprised by his persecution, he wished he were dead or had never been born (see Jeremiah 16:3–4; Job 3).

Jeremiah 20:16

The ancient cities were likely Sodom and Gomorrah (Genesis 19:24–29).

Jeremiah 20:17–18

Jeremiah felt his life had no purpose.

Jeremiah 21:1

- King Zedekiah ruled from 597 to 586 BC.
- The Pashhur mentioned here is different from the one in Jeremiah 20:1–6 because they had different fathers. He and Zephaniah held full authority from the king. Yet, when they met the prophet, they asked Jeremiah for the Lord's help. They clearly saw Jeremiah as a man of great authority. Zedekiah acknowledged Jeremiah's prophetic authority, but he lacked the courage or moral integrity to follow Jeremiah's guidance in the Lord's name.

Jeremiah 21:1–10

This section begins with the Babylonian siege of Jerusalem in 588 BC (see Jeremiah 52:1–23; 2 Kings 24:18–25:21; 2 Chronicles 36:11–21). The Lord spoke to Judah through his messenger Jeremiah.

Jeremiah 21:1–28.17

From this point in the book of Jeremiah, you will find details about the last kings of Judah, especially Jehoiakim and Zedekiah. The stories are mostly in prose and not always in order.

Jeremiah 21:2

- Nebuchadnezzar ...is waging war against us: This likely happened around the start of the siege of Jerusalem in 588 BC (2 Kings 25:1).
- Zedekiah did not pray to the Lord like his ancestor Hezekiah did (2 Kings 19:14–20, 29–37; 2 Chronicles 32:20–22; Isaiah 37:1–7, 14–20). However, the king expected Jeremiah to perform a miracle to turn away the Lord's anger.

Jeremiah 21:3–7

The Lord gave King Zedekiah's messengers a legal decision (see study note on Jeremiah 2:2). Resisting the Babylonians would be pointless because the Lord opposed Jerusalem.

Jeremiah 21:8–10

The Lord decided to destroy Jerusalem, but people could choose life, likely as slaves in Babylon, or death by Babylonian swords (see Deuteronomy 20:10–13).

Jeremiah 21:11–12

The Lord told the royal family of Judah to treat people fairly or face His anger.

Jeremiah 21:11–14

Instead of performing a miracle for David's dynasty, God planned to hold them accountable for their sins.

Jeremiah 21:13–14

- The people in Jerusalem trusted completely in the city's strong fortress, believing it was unbeatable (see 2 Kings 18:35–37; 2 Chronicles 32:20–23; Isaiah 37:36–38). The Lord had protected the city before, but now the Lord opposed it.
- I will kindle a fire in your forest: See Isaiah 6:13.

Jeremiah 22:1–5

Jeremiah gave a message based on the Sinai covenant. It outlined the duties of a king of Judah. If the king fulfilled these duties, the dynasty of David would continue in Jerusalem. If the king refused, the palace and kingdom would vanish.

Jeremiah 22:1–23.8

This collection of messages to the last kings from David's line in Judah ends with a promise. God will one day appoint a true descendant of David to lead his people.

Jeremiah 22:3

Judah's leaders acted unfairly and unjustly. They did not help robbery victims or rescue the oppressed. They mistreated foreigners, orphans, and widows (see Isaiah 58:6–7; Micah 6:8; Zechariah 7:9–10; 8:16–17; Matthew 23:23).

Jeremiah 22:6–7

- Farmers grew valuable crops in the valleys and on the slopes of Gilead. Gilead is the highlands that rise eastward from the Jordan Valley.
- Lebanon is the area north of Israel along the seacoast. It includes a high mountain ridge on the country's eastern side. Lebanon was famous for its tall cedar trees.

Jeremiah 22:6–9

After the Temple, Judah's royal palace was the nation's most important building. Skilled craftsmen built this expensive structure (1 Kings 7:1–12). It served as the king's home and the center of his government. Although the Lord valued the palace, it would not avoid the destruction he planned for Jerusalem.

Jeremiah 22:8–9

The destruction of Jerusalem would show other nations what happens when Judah breaks their agreement with the Lord, their God.

Jeremiah 22:10–12

King Josiah died in 609 BC, killed by the Egyptians at the Battle of Megiddo. The people of Judah were not to mourn his death. Instead, they should focus their sorrow on Josiah's son, whom they had chosen as the new king. After three months, King Jehoahaz was exiled to Egypt, where he lived for the rest of his life (2 Kings 23:1–33; 2 Chronicles 36:1–8).

Jeremiah 22:10–30

This section presents serious accusations against Josiah's descendants.

Jeremiah 22:13

Jehoiakim made poor men work as unpaid slaves, so his building projects were unjust from the start.

Jeremiah 22:13–23

Egypt put another of Josiah's sons, Eliakim, on the throne in Jerusalem and changed his name to Jehoiakim. Most of the material in Jeremiah 7–20 was likely written during Jehoiakim's reign, from 609 to 598 BC. The Lord accused him of being unfaithful and greedy, put him on trial, found him guilty, and sentenced him to death.

Jeremiah 22:14

great palace: Archaeologists have discovered the foundations of this palace three miles south of Jerusalem. The foundations show that the building had very large rooms.

Jeremiah 22:15–16

If Jehoiakim wanted plenty to eat and drink, he did not need to use corruption and oppression. Compared to his prosperous father, Josiah, Jehoiakim was not a great king. Josiah, on the other hand, was fair and honest in all his actions, serving both God and his people. Because he followed the ancient covenant's rules, God blessed him.

Jeremiah 22:17

Jehoiakim, unlike his father Josiah, was greedy and dishonest. He ignored the covenant's requirements.

Jeremiah 22:18–23

God judged Jehoiakim for his terrible sins. Neither his family nor his people would mourn him.

Jeremiah 22:19

Jehoiakim died in shame (see study note on 2 Kings 24:6).

Jeremiah 22:20

- Jehoiakim might have thought that nearby nations, like Lebanon and Bashan, would help him during a crisis. They could not, because the Babylonians had already destroyed them.
- Bashan was in the region east of the Jordan River.

Jeremiah 22:22

- The days of prosperity had ended, and chaos covered Judah. Like a wind sweeping through the land, the Babylonians would defeat Judah's allies and take many captives.
- Then you will be: Royal self-delusions would vanish, and the consequences of wickedness would bring shame to the king.

Jeremiah 22:24–30

Jehoiachin, the son of Jehoiakim, became king at eighteen in 597 BC. The Babylonians attacked Jerusalem because his father rebelled against Nebuchadnezzar. After just three months as king, Jehoiachin wisely surrendered and was taken captive to Babylon (2 Kings 24:8–14), along with most of the royal family.

Jeremiah 22:25–27

Young King Jehoiachin feared the Babylonians would kill him, but they exiled him instead.

Jeremiah 22:28–30

This poem taunts Jehoiachin with two rhetorical questions, both expecting the answer, "I do not know." Jehoiachin's sins and his ancestors' wrongdoings caused his fate. Yet, the people of Jerusalem seemed unwilling to accept the fairness of his exile.

Jeremiah 22:29

O land: God calls nature as a witness against his unfaithful people (see also Jeremiah 6:19; Deuteronomy 30:19; Isaiah 1:2).

Jeremiah 22:30

Jehoiachin had seven sons (see 1 Chronicles 3:17), but people called him childless because none of his sons became king of Judah. His uncle Zedekiah later ruled as king of Judah. However, many Israelites considered Jehoiachin the last true king of David's dynasty (see study note on Ezekiel 1:2).

Jeremiah 23:1

In the ancient Near East, people often called kings shepherds. Good shepherds protected and cared for their people. However, Judah's kings scattered their people.

Jeremiah 23:1–8

The Lord criticized the three kings (Jeremiah 22) and compared them to the good leader he would appoint for his people after the Exile.

Jeremiah 23:3

As a good shepherd, the Lord would gather the exiles and place them in their own sheepfold, the land of Judah. There, they would grow and increase in number (compare Genesis 1:28; 17:6–8).

Jeremiah 23:4

Once the people returned to Judah (Jeremiah 23:3), the Lord would appoint responsible shepherds. These good leaders would care for the people.

Jeremiah 23:5

A righteous descendant from King David's line, whose rule had paused, would become a King. Unlike the three kings the Lord had just criticized (Jeremiah 22), this King would have wisdom and act justly and rightly (Jeremiah 33:15; Isaiah 11:1–5; 53:2; Zechariah 3:8; Luke 1:32–33).

Jeremiah 23:6

This ruler would be called The Lord Our Righteousness (Hebrew Yahweh Tsidqenu). This name is an interesting reversal of Zedekiah's Hebrew name (Tsidqiyyahu), which means "Righteous is the Lord." Zedekiah's character and the chaos during his reign were the opposite of the future King's character. The future King's reign would bring salvation and safety.

Jeremiah 23:9–10

Jeremiah stood before the Lord, shocked by the harshness of the Lord's judgments against the religious leaders.

Jeremiah 23:9–32

These short poems and interjections seem to be parts of a session where the Lord prepared Jeremiah to confront the false prophets of Jerusalem. These leaders misused the Lord's name, which made him angry (Exodus 20:7).

Jeremiah 23:10

People everywhere committed adultery. They believed the ritual sex in Baal worship would ensure good crops. Instead, it caused a drought that ruined crops in Judah.

Jeremiah 23:11

Judah's religious leaders had done terrible things. They did these not only in private and in places of pagan worship but also in the Temple, in front of the Lord.

Jeremiah 23:12

Because of their wickedness, these priests and prophets would have unstable lives; danger would fill every moment.

Jeremiah 23:13–14

- Samaria, the capital of the northern kingdom of Israel, was dominated by Baal worship, which the government prophets supported (1 Kings 18:19; see also Jeremiah 16:12). The religious leaders of Judah were even worse.
- Sodom and Gomorrah represented the worst of this wickedness (Genesis 18:20).

Jeremiah 23:15

While people were responsible for their own sins, the prophets were blamed for Jerusalem's spiritual betrayal.

Jeremiah 23:16

The false prophets gave the people false hopes; they were not chosen to speak for the Lord, and their ideas came from their own minds.

Jeremiah 23:16–32

The Lord urged the people to ignore these prophets and listen to his word instead.

Jeremiah 23:17

These prophets lied to the people, telling them peace would come soon, even though they ignored the Lord's word. However, the Lord had already decided on destruction.

Jeremiah 23:18–19

These prophets made up their messages (Jeremiah 23:16); they had never been in the Lord's presence, and none of them cared to listen to God's instruction.

Jeremiah 23:19–20

Despite the false prophets' lies, the world faced the Lord's anger. The political situation was like a storm that would soon hit the wicked. The Lord planned this punishment and would make sure it happened. After the war, the survivors would look back and see that Jeremiah's prophecy was correct.

Jeremiah 23:21–24

In this stanza, the Lord shows his strong disappointment and disgust with the false prophets.

Jeremiah 23:22

If the false prophets' messages had come from the Lord, they would have been different. God wanted the people to stop their evil actions, like Baal worship, and follow the one true God.

Jeremiah 23:23–24

The Lord showed how he differs from Canaanite nature gods. Pagan gods were part of nature and nearby. The Lord is near because he created nature, but he is also distinct from it. His essence is different from nature, yet he is present in all the heavens and earth.

Jeremiah 23:25–27

The false prophets valued dreams highly. Claiming to have a dream supposedly gave their message authority. However, these prophets made up everything to lead people away from the Lord.

Jeremiah 23:28

The Lord temporarily let the false prophets share their dreams. Meanwhile, the Lord had his true messengers, like Jeremiah, proclaim every word. This helped people see the difference between the false prophets' useless dreams (straw) and the nourishing words of the Lord's messengers (grain); compare Psalm 1:3–4.

Jeremiah 23:29

The Lord's word is powerful, like fire, and can destroy false prophecies. It would smash the strong fortress of Jerusalem like a mighty hammer.

Jeremiah 23:30–32

The Lord criticized and opposed the prophets who lied in his name.

Jeremiah 23:33

- The false prophets might mock Jeremiah by asking for the latest message from the Lord.
- What burden?: This is a wordplay. People often called a prophetic message "a burden." The false prophets were a heavy load that the Lord would discard and abandon.

Jeremiah 23:33–40

The Lord gave Jeremiah an example conversation to teach him how to deal with false prophets.

Jeremiah 23:34–35

A person might falsely claim to have heard a prophecy from the Lord. However, that person and their entire family would face punishment (compare Numbers 16:27–32; Joshua 7:24–25).

Jeremiah 23:36

The Lord warned that no one should claim to have a prophecy from Him to control others. This would go

against God's words and misuse His name (Exodus 20:7; see also Matthew 20:25–28).

Jeremiah 23:37–40

What has the LORD spoken?: The Lord has decided to punish the people of Judah and remove false prophets. Any prophecy claiming otherwise is not from the Lord.

Jeremiah 23:40

People would mock the false prophets. Their predictions would be wrong when Jerusalem was destroyed and its people were taken into exile.

Jeremiah 24:1

- In 597 BC, King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon captured Jehoiachin and took him to Babylon. Jehoiachin's surrender saved Jerusalem, but its treasures and 10,000 of its important citizens went into exile (2 Kings 24:8–16).
- Usually, people displayed baskets of figs in a market, not in the Temple area.

Jeremiah 24:1–10

This section discusses the meaning of the exile in 597 BC. Some people said it was God's way of removing the bad figs from the basket(Jerusalem) so the good figs could survive. Jeremiah argued the opposite. The good figs were taken out of the basket (into exile) so the bad figs would not destroy them.

Jeremiah 24:4–7

The people exiled from Jerusalem had a better future than those who stayed. The Lord would create a new community with the exiles (see Jeremiah 1:10).

Jeremiah 24:7

- The Lord would do a wonderful work in the hearts of the exiles, helping them to recognize (literally know) the Lord as a personal God (1 Chronicles 28:9; Psalms 9:10; 36:10; Isaiah 19:21; 52:6; Daniel 11:32; Hosea 2:20; Titus 1:16; 1 John 4:6–8).
- They will be My people, and I will be their God: God's covenant with Israel would become a personal reality for them (Exodus 6:7; 19:5; Deuteronomy 29:13; Revelation 21:7).
- all their heart: The exiles would not mix religious loyalties; they would be fully committed to the one true God.

Jeremiah 24:8–10

The bad figs were those left in Jerusalem, and the Lord would scatter them because they were rotten. This group included everyone from the rest of the royal family to the common people. In 586 BC, Zedekiah's reign ended just as predicted here.

Jeremiah 25:1

One of the first actions of Babylon's King Nebuchadnezzar was to make Judah's King Jehoiakim pledge loyalty to him.

Jeremiah 25:1–14

The Lord had been patient with Jerusalem's rebellion and refusal to listen, but now it was time for judgment.

Jeremiah 25:3

Jeremiah started his ministry in 627 BC.

Jeremiah 25:4

For many generations, God sent prophets to the people, but they ignored the Lord's warnings.

Jeremiah 25:5–6

The Lord asked his people to stop doing evil things that made him angry. If they did, he would not harm them but would give them his promised blessings.

Jeremiah 25:7–9

The people ignored the Lord's rules and continued their evil ways by worshiping idols. As a result, the Lord decided to destroy them completely.

Jeremiah 25:10

- All celebrations, even simple joys like singing and laughter, would stop.
- Millstones...light: After Judah's destruction, no one would be left to work or enjoy its benefits.

Jeremiah 25:11

seventy years: This is the first time a specific period is assigned to the Exile. The prediction was fulfilled either from 605 BC (the first exile to Babylon) to around 538 BC (when Cyrus allowed the exiles to return to Judea), or from 586 BC (the destruction of the Temple) to 515 BC (the dedication of the Second Temple). Alternatively, the number can be seen as symbolic, representing God's judgment on Jerusalem lasting a perfect lifetime, exactly as God determined.

Jeremiah 25:12–14

The Lord used the Babylonians to judge Judah, but they would face consequences for their sins, brutality, and abuse of the defeated. In 539 BC, Cyrus the

Persian conquered Babylon, and the people went into captivity. For centuries, many nations and great kings enslaved the Babylonians. The territory did not regain independence until 1932, becoming modern Iraq.

Jeremiah 25:15

The Lord gave Jeremiah messages of wrath, symbolized as a cup filled with the wine of the Lord's anger (Revelation 14:10). Jeremiah was to make the nations drink from it. God wanted them to hear the messages of condemnation and experience the promised judgment.

Jeremiah 25:15–38

- The Lord is the supreme ruler of all nations, and their rebellion was about to bring judgment.
- To whom I send you: Jeremiah did not travel to each nation in person. The message he delivered from the Lord spread mainly through written material, much of it in the book of Jeremiah, which people have read worldwide.

Jeremiah 25:16

When they drank from the cup (Jeremiah 25:15), the nations would stagger like they were drunk. The warfare would drive them crazy, making them unable to protect themselves. They would feel hopeless and helpless. In their confusion, they would panic.

Jeremiah 25:17

So I...made all the nations drink from it: Jeremiah did this by announcing God's judgment.

Jeremiah 25:18

- Everyone drank from the cup, meaning the leaders heard the words of judgment.
- as they are to this day: Jeremiah likely delivered the Lord's messages during the siege and fall of Jerusalem, from 588 to 586 BC.

Jeremiah 25:19–20

- Many refugees who fled from Judah and nearby countries to Egypt when the Babylonians invaded heard the prophet's message.
- Uz was a region on Arabia's northern border. Ashkelon, Gaza, Ekron, and Ashdod were Philistine cities near the Mediterranean Sea.

Jeremiah 25:21–22

The small nations of Edom, Moab, and Ammon were east and southeast of the Dead Sea. The Phoenician cities of Tyre and Sidon were to the northwest, along the Mediterranean Sea. The regions across the sea were likely the islands of Cyprus and Crete.

Jeremiah 25:23–26

Dedan, Tema, Buz, and Zimri were in the desert area east of the Jordan Valley, north of Arabia. Elam and Media, located in the highlands east of Babylon, formed the core of the Persian Empire. This empire conquered Babylon in 539 BC.

Jeremiah 25:27–29

These kingdoms had to face the Lord's anger (see study note on Jeremiah 25:15). They could not escape the disaster that would overwhelm them. Jerusalem experienced God's judgment, and the surrounding nations would too.

Jeremiah 25:30–31

First, the Lord spoke through Jeremiah about his own land, Judah. Then, Jeremiah delivered God's messages of judgment to everyone on earth.

Jeremiah 25:32–33

Disaster...a mighty storm: These words highlight the terrible wars that destroyed many nations in the 500s BC.

Jeremiah 25:34–35

- The earth's cruel leaders (shepherds) were harsh rulers of the nations.
- roll in the dust: This is a sign of distress.

Jeremiah 25:36

destroying their pasture: The nations led by wicked leaders (Jeremiah 25:34) would be destroyed because the Lord would carry out his judgment.

Jeremiah 25:37–38

The Lord's judgment would be as terrifying as a strong lion hunting its prey. The nations would be helpless against the Lord's fierce anger.

Jeremiah 25:38

After this verse, the Greek translation of the Old Testament, called the Septuagint, includes Jeremiah 46–51. These chapters mainly discuss the nations mentioned in Jeremiah 25.

Jeremiah 26:1–24

Jeremiah went on trial in front of the priests and prophets. The trial focused on the Temple's holiness

because Jeremiah said the Lord would destroy both the Temple and Jerusalem.

Jeremiah 26:2

Jeremiah stood in the Temple courtyard because the people of Judah gathered there for the yearly festivals.

Jeremiah 26:3

The Lord gave the people a choice about their future. If they turned from their evil ways, the Lord would reconsider. The standard of judgment was his covenant with Israel (see Deuteronomy 5:1–21; 27:1–28:68). When Israel obeyed the covenant, the Lord blessed them. When Israel persistently and stubbornly disobeyed, the Lord eventually punished them.

Jeremiah 26:4–6

The ancestors of the people chose disobedience, which led to the destruction of their sanctuary at Shiloh, north of Jerusalem (Jeremiah 7:12–15; 1 Samuel 1–4). In the same way, if the people in Jeremiah's time continued to disobey the covenant commands, the Temple and Jerusalem would be destroyed.

Jeremiah 26:7–9

The crowd at the Temple wanted to kill Jeremiah for blasphemy because he spoke against the Temple. This charge carried the death penalty (Leviticus 24:16). The prophet's opponents argued that the Lord's holy Temple could not be destroyed. The priests and prophets believed the pagan idea that temples were indestructible because gods lived in them.

Jeremiah 26:10–15

Court trials usually took place at a city gateway. At this time, city gateways were covered and had multiple chambers. This location was busy with city commerce. The city elders gathered here to offer their wisdom on legal conflicts. In this case, the officials were fair and allowed each party to present its side of the dispute.

Jeremiah 26:12–13

Jeremiah said the Lord sent him to speak against the city and the Temple. He added that disaster would not happen if the people of Jerusalem obeyed the Lord.

Jeremiah 26:14–15

Jeremiah calmly accepted the authority and trusted the officials with his life. However, he warned them they would be responsible if they killed an innocent man.

Jeremiah 26:16

Jeremiah successfully defended himself. He convinced the officials and people of his innocence because he spoke for the Lord.

Jeremiah 26:17–19

- In the ancient Near East, societies greatly respected wise old men. Few people lived to old age, and those who did had valuable memories.
- Micah of Moresheth lived during King Hezekiah's reign, from 728 to 686 BC, over 100 years earlier. Micah wrote a small collection of prophecies. The elders quoted a verse (Micah 3:12) predicting the destruction of Mount Zion and Jerusalem. These elders advised the people to follow Hezekiah's example by turning from sin and worshiping the Lord. Although the people of Judah decided not to harm Jeremiah, they ignored the second part of the elders' advice.

Jeremiah 26:24

Ahikam served under King Josiah (2 Kings 22:12–14).

Jeremiah 27:1–22

The Lord told Jeremiah to send messages to the ambassadors from nearby countries to announce the Lord's judgment on them. Jeremiah was to show his message by wearing a wooden yoke. This event happened in 594 to 593 BC (see Jeremiah 28:1).

Jeremiah 27:4–5

The full power of the divine name supported this message (see study note on Jeremiah 2:2). The Lord's authority over everything directly challenged the false nature gods worshiped by each nation mentioned.

Jeremiah 27:6–8

God gave Nebuchadnezzar control over the entire region, so resisting him was pointless. All nations would serve him and his descendants. Cyrus conquered Babylon in 539 BC during Belshazzar's reign, who was Nebuchadnezzar's grandson.

Jeremiah 27:8

his…yoke: Compare Jeremiah 21:8–10; 27:2–3.

Jeremiah 27:9–10

- Jeremiah warned against those who delivered messages that went against the Lord's:
- [False] prophets made predictions that supported idol worship

- diviners claimed to predict the future by reading the stars, looking into crystal balls, and analyzing animal livers
- Interpreters of dreams predicted the future by explaining people's dreams
- Mediums claimed to talk to dead people
- Sorcerers cast spells to harm or bless people by saying certain words or phrases
- You will not serve the king of Babylon: This prediction was incorrect. Nebuchadnezzar conquered the entire region starting in 605 BC.

Jeremiah 27:12–15

God's decree (Jeremiah 27:4–11) applied to Judah and the nearby nations equally.

Jeremiah 27:16

People took the gold items and other treasures from the Temple in 597 BC.

Jeremiah 27:18–19

People even asked the false prophets to repent and pray to the Lord.

Jeremiah 27:20–22

When King Jehoiachin of Judah was captured, King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon left the large, valuable furniture in the Temple. He took all of it in 586 BC.

Jeremiah 27:22

When Cyrus of Persia allowed the exiles to return in 538 BC, they brought the Temple furnishings back to Jerusalem (Ezra 1:7–11; 5:13–15).

Jeremiah 28:1

The people were in the temple, so it was likely during one of the annual fall festivals. It could have been the Day of Atonement (Leviticus 23:26–32) or the Feast of Tabernacles (Leviticus 23:33–36).

Jeremiah 28:1–17

Shortly after the events of Jeremiah 27, a false prophet named Hananiah publicly challenged Jeremiah in the Temple courtyard. Each prophet claimed to deliver a message from the Lord, but only Jeremiah's prediction was accurate.

Jeremiah 28:2–3

- Hananiah's message was the accepted propaganda, but he used strong words (Jeremiah 27:4) to claim the Lord's authority.
- Judah had been under the control of the king of Babylon since 597 BC.

Jeremiah 28:4

- The false prophet's message claimed that Jehoiachin would return. This implied that Zedekiah had a lower status as ruler over the kingdom of Judah (see study note on Ezekiel 1:2).
- declares the LORD: Hananiah ended with the same strong appeal to divine authority that Jeremiah often used.

Jeremiah 28:5–6

Amen! (literally So be it!): Jeremiah would have been pleased if this prediction came true.

Jeremiah 28:7–9

People can be sure a prophet speaks the Lord's word only if his predictions come true (Deuteronomy 18:20–22).

Jeremiah 28:10–11

- The false prophet Hananiah broke the yoke that Jeremiah was wearing (Jeremiah 27:2) as a sign of what the Lord would do.
- Jeremiah left the confrontation without replying, likely because he had not yet heard the Lord's response.

Jeremiah 28:12–14

Jeremiah delivered the Lord's response to the false prophecy. Hananiah broke a wooden yoke, but it was replaced by a symbolic iron yoke. Submission to Babylon was certain because the Lord had decreed it.

Jeremiah 28:15–17

You will die: The Lord decreed that Hananiah must die, as the law required for false prophets (Deuteronomy 13:1–5). The Lord enforced this decree that same year. Jeremiah's prophecy proved true when fulfilled two months later. In contrast, Hananiah's prediction that the Temple treasures would return in two years did not come true. The Lord showed he remained in control.

Jeremiah 29:1–23

Jeremiah sent a letter to the Hebrew exiles in Babylon. People read his letter many times in different settlements to reach all the scattered Israelites.

Jeremiah 29:2

had been exiled from Jerusalem: This refers to the exile in 597 BC.

Jeremiah 29:5–7

Jeremiah encouraged the exiled people to prepare for a long stay in Babylon. God wanted them to become productive citizens, caring for and praying to the Lord for the well-being of the Babylonian communities where they lived. This would help their population grow. They should not listen to false prophecies like Hananiah's, which promised a quick return home.

Jeremiah 29:8–9

The next divine command warned against false prophets and people who claim to tell the future.

Jeremiah 29:10

The exiled people of Judah would stay in Babylon for seventy years; this was not new information (see Jeremiah 25:11), but Jeremiah's audiences in Jerusalem had not believed him. Now that they were in exile, they needed to accept reality.

Jeremiah 29:11

The Lord planned to help the exiled people prosper and return to Judah, giving them a future and hope. This promise was for the exiles in Babylon, but it has also given hope to millions of God's people in tough situations.

Jeremiah 29:12–13

Through Jeremiah, the Lord reminded the exiled people that if they searched for him sincerely, they would find him. The Exile taught the Israelites to reject false gods and devote themselves fully to the Lord (Deuteronomy 6:4–6). It also inspired a new commitment to God's revealed word.

Jeremiah 29:15

False prophets were among the exiles. They promised that Jerusalem would survive and the Exile would end soon.

Jeremiah 29:16–18

The Lord reminded the exiles in Babylon that those left in Jerusalem would also face disaster. The bad figs in Jerusalem would experience horror later (see Jeremiah 24:6–10).

Jeremiah 29:20–22

- Even though Jeremiah was in Jerusalem, God told him what was happening in Babylon. Similarly, God informed Ezekiel in Babylon about events in Jerusalem (Ezekiel 8).
- The Lord identified two prophets who were spreading lies in His name and sentenced them to death (Deuteronomy 18:20–22; compare Jeremiah 26:14–15; 28:16–17).

Jeremiah 29:24–32

A prophet in Babylon named Shemaiah disagreed with Jeremiah's advice that the exiles should accept a long exile (Jeremiah 29:4–23). Shemaiah sent a letter to a leading priest in Jerusalem, urging action against Jeremiah. In response, Jeremiah wrote a letter to the exiles condemning Shemaiah.

Jeremiah 29:29

Zephaniah wisely showed Jeremiah the letter from Shemaiah.

Jeremiah 29:30–32

Shemaiah did not have a commission from the Lord, so he was a liar. He tried to convince the exiles that their exile would be short. Using the Lord's authority three times (see study note on Jeremiah 2:2), Shemaiah was charged, found guilty, and sentenced to execution.

Jeremiah 30:1–24

This series of messages is mostly positive, with only two verses having a judgmental tone (Jeremiah 30:23–24). They describe the positive outcomes of Jerusalem's destruction and the Exile.

Jeremiah 30:1–33.26

People often call these four chapters "The Book of Consolation," a highlight in Old Testament revelation. Unlike the many judgment messages Jeremiah gave his people, these messages are full of hope and promise a wonderful future restoration.

Jeremiah 30:3

- The new messages build on the theme of Jeremiah 29:10–14 (see 3:18; 16:15; 24:6). The fall of Jerusalem

and the Exile did not end the Lord's relationship with Israel. The Lord planned a bright future for the remaining people. Descendants of those from the northern kingdom of Israel, exiled by the Assyrians in 722 BC, would return. Similarly, descendants of Judah's people, exiled to Babylon in 597 and 586 BC, would come back to the Promised Land.
- I will restore them to the land: The first major return from exile happened in 538 BC (Ezra 1:1–6:22), the second in 458 BC (Ezra 7:1–10:44), and the third in 445 BC (Nehemiah 1–13).

Jeremiah 30:7

The time of trouble was when Babylon captured and destroyed Judah in 586 BC.

Jeremiah 30:8

The exiles started returning in 538 BC, but foreigners ruled Israel for most of its history from the Exile to the Roman period. However, Israel did enjoy some freedom during this time.

Jeremiah 30:9

- After the Exile, the Israelites stopped worshiping idols and truly served the Lord their God.
- The Lord would provide a king, a descendant of David, who would be called the Messiah (Isaiah 55:3–4; Ezekiel 34:23; 37:24; Hosea 3:5; Luke 1:69; Acts 2:30; 13:22–23).

Jeremiah 30:10

The gathering of exiles would include those in Babylon and those scattered in faraway lands. The Lord promised gifts of peace and quiet without frightening enemies.

Jeremiah 30:11

The Lord could make these promises because he was with his people and had the power to save them. He promised to destroy cruel nations and protect his people. However, the Lord would correct his people if they sinned.

Jeremiah 30:12–14

- The exiles experienced an injury (a grievous wound) due to their many sins.
- your lovers: The Lord used these terms for nations, especially Egypt, that had been Judah's trusted friends (see Jeremiah 4:30; Ezekiel 16:15–63).

Jeremiah 30:15

The Israelites could not protest their punishment. They deserved their exile, and God's justice required their punishment.

Jeremiah 30:16

all who devour you will be devoured: See Jeremiah 25:11–12.

Jeremiah 30:17

I will…heal your wounds: The people will return from exile, and their sins will be forgiven.

Jeremiah 30:18

Nehemiah led the rebuilding of Jerusalem's walls in 445 BC (Nehemiah 12:22–43).

Jeremiah 30:19–21

The rebuilt Jerusalem would be the heart of a strong and thriving nation. Its increasing population would feel joy and sing songs of thanks. The city would earn respect from its neighbors, and its streets would be full of children who would grow up and succeed. The nation would have its own leader again.

Jeremiah 30:22

The Lord wanted to create a nation where people fully dedicated themselves to worshiping him as the only true God (Exodus 6:7; Ezekiel 36:38).

Jeremiah 30:23

The reestablished nation was still responsible for its rebellion. The Lord had the power to show his strong anger against the wicked.

Jeremiah 30:24

Punishment was an important part of the Lord's plan. The Israelites, including Jeremiah, struggled to understand how God's promises fit with His anger. Reflecting on past events later would help them understand this contradiction.

Jeremiah 31:1

- At that time: This phrase refers to the return from exile that started in 538 BC.
- all the families of Israel: The upcoming restoration included all twelve tribes of Israel.

Jeremiah 31:2

The Lord sent his message to those who would survive the destruction when Jerusalem fell in 586 BC.

Jeremiah 31:3

Long ago, the Lord showed himself during the Exodus (see Exodus 15:13; 20:6; 34:6–7; Numbers 14:18–19; Deuteronomy 5:10; 7:7, 10, 12–13; 10:15, 18).

Jeremiah 31:4

In their homeland, the Israelites had worshipped false gods. The restored community would be like a virgin, as if the people had never left the Lord. Their celebrations would show this change through happiness and joy.

Jeremiah 31:5

Samaria was in the north-central part of Israel.

Jeremiah 31:6

In the completely restored nation, the kingdom will not be divided anymore (1 Kings 12:16–29; Ezekiel 37:16–22).

Jeremiah 31:7

The remnant refers to people living in exile.

Jeremiah 31:8

- The Lord promised to gather the surviving exiles from wherever they were scattered, including the weak and helpless.
- The large group of exiles who returned in 538 to 536 BC numbered 49,697 (Ezra 2:64).

Jeremiah 31:9

Those returning to their homeland would cry with joy, knowing the Lord is their shepherd (Psalm 23:1–3) and feeling secure (see Isaiah 35:10) with God as their father.

Jeremiah 31:10

The Lord promised to gather his people from all nations and be their shepherd, replacing the wicked leaders who misled Israel and Judah.

Jeremiah 31:11

Only the Lord could free the people from exile.

Jeremiah 31:12

The restored community would enjoy the Lord's gifts. The people could expect abundant crops to grow without asking Baal for help. They would leave behind the sorrows of exile. Those returning could expect to be fruitful, like a well-watered garden.

Jeremiah 31:13

The Lord would replace mourning, a daily experience in exile, with his comfort and constant joy (see Isaiah 40:1–3; 61:3).

Jeremiah 31:14

The priests and the people would have plenty because the people would pay their tithes instead of taking from God (Malachi 3:8–12).

Jeremiah 31:15

- Rachel, Jacob's favorite wife, was the mother of Joseph and Benjamin. Joseph was the father of the tribes of Ephraim and Manasseh in the northern kingdom. Benjamin's descendants were in the southern kingdom. She symbolized all Israeli mothers whose children were taken into exile.
- Matthew 2:18 refers to this verse regarding the killing of young boys in Bethlehem.

Jeremiah 31:15–40

The Lord explained his future plan to rebuild a new nation from people who had suffered greatly during their long captivity.

Jeremiah 31:16–17

Rachel should not cry, because the Lord promised to return her exiled children to their land.

Jeremiah 31:18–19

Israel was now sorry for its sins and humbly asked for restoration. The people realized they could not save themselves. They turned away from idols and affirmed that God alone is the Lord.

Jeremiah 31:19

The exiles felt ashamed when they understood the foolishness of their sins.

Jeremiah 31:20

The exiled people were always in the Lord's thoughts. God responded to their repentance with a father's love for his lost children (compare Luke 15:11–24).

Jeremiah 31:21

road markers…signposts: The Lord led his people back to Israel and restored their spiritual relationship with Him.

Jeremiah 31:26

It seems that either Jeremiah or his scribe fell asleep and woke up suddenly. His sleep was very sweet, like the rest and joy promised by the Lord (Jeremiah 31:25).

Jeremiah 31:27

The Lord's care for Israel and Judah would be clear through their growing population and the many animals grazing in their fields.

Jeremiah 31:28

The future involves the return of the exiled people to the Promised Land. The Lord had promised to plant and build them there (see Jeremiah 1:10).

Jeremiah 31:29–30

Some people think this proverb (likely a misunderstanding of Exodus 20:5; 34:7; Numbers 14:18) meant innocent children died because of their parents' sins. The Lord clarified that each person is punished for their own sins (see Lamentations 5:7; Ezekiel 18:2–32; 33:10–20).

Jeremiah 31:31

The new covenant began when Jesus Christ completed his mission to save humanity on earth (see Hebrews 8:8–12).

Jeremiah 31:32–34

The main difference between the new covenant and the one God made with their ancestors is that the Lord would write his instructions deep within people's hearts (see Hebrews 10:16). The old covenant was external and legal, while the new covenant would be a personal relationship. The new covenant would focus on changing and transforming a person's spiritual nature.

Jeremiah 31:34

- The old covenant had to be taught (see Deuteronomy 6:4–9), but the new covenant focuses on a personal relationship with the Lord.
- I will forgive: Each believer who repents will experience God's forgiveness.
- I...will remember their sins no more: Once sins are forgiven, they will not lead to divine judgment (see Hebrews 10:17).
- Jesus' death started the new covenant (see Matthew 26:28; Mark 14:24; Luke 22:20; 1 Corinthians 11:25; 2 Corinthians 3:6; Hebrews 8; 9:15; 12:22–24).

Jeremiah 31:35–37

The Lord compared his promise of the new covenant to his reliability in upholding the laws of nature.

Jeremiah 31:38

The Lord revealed his plan to rebuild Jerusalem. The Tower of Hananel was at the northeast corner of the old city. The Corner Gate was at the northwest corner (2 Kings 14:13; 2 Chronicles 26:9).

Jeremiah 31:39

Gareb and Goah are not mentioned elsewhere in the Bible, but they were likely on the city's west side.

Jeremiah 31:40

- Jerusalem will be an eternal holy city, present in the heavenly realm and on the new earth (Revelation 21–22).
- The graveyard and ash dump were in the Valley of Ben-Hinnom (see study note on Jeremiah 7:30–34) on the south side of the city, and the Kidron Valley was on the east (2 Kings 23:4–6).
- The exact location of the Horse Gate on the eastern wall is unknown.

Jeremiah 32:2

- Jerusalem had been under siege since January 588 BC (2 Kings 25:1).
- Jeremiah supported surrendering to the Babylonians, but this idea angered many who believed they could resist the foreign army. To protect Jeremiah, Zedekiah imprisoned him in the courtyard of the guard (Jeremiah 37:21).

Jeremiah 32:4–5

Resisting the Babylonians was hopeless. It would lead to disaster for the city and for Zedekiah.

Jeremiah 32:6–8

- Anathoth was the hometown of Jeremiah (Jeremiah 1:1).
- According to Hebrew law, Jeremiah's cousin had to offer the land first to his closest relative (see Leviticus 25:25, 32; Ruth 4:1–4).

Jeremiah 32:9–12

- Many people might have thought Jeremiah acted foolishly when he agreed to buy the land. After Jerusalem fell and many people went into exile, the land's value would drop to almost nothing. Still, Jeremiah immediately bought the field.

- Matthew 27:9–10 refers to the "what was spoken through Jeremiah the prophet," which might allude to this event.

Jeremiah 32:10

Jeremiah followed the legal steps to buy property. The purchase deed was a papyrus sheet with terms in Hebrew. Jeremiah signed, sealed the deed, and paid in front of witnesses (Genesis 23:3–18; 2 Samuel 24:20–24).

Jeremiah 32:11–12

By tradition, they made a copy of the deed. Jeremiah's secretary, Baruch, took care of both documents. This happened publicly in the guardhouse courtyard.

Jeremiah 32:13–14

By tradition, they placed two copies of the deed in a pottery jar to preserve them for a long time.

Jeremiah 32:15

Jeremiah explained why he made the purchase: He was investing in the future that God had promised. Someday, exiled survivors from the destruction of Judah would return, and the worthless land would become productive and valuable again. Jeremiah had already predicted that the exile would last for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11–12; 29:10). Jeremiah's purchase showed his faith in the Lord's plan to restore his people.

Jeremiah 32:16

Jeremiah prayed after he bought the land.

Jeremiah 32:16–25

This prayer of Jeremiah was different from his earlier ones. Those were full of anguish, despair, and even criticism of the Lord's treatment of Judah. This prayer was calm, affirming, and worshipful.

Jeremiah 32:17

As the all-powerful Creator of everything, the Sovereign Lord could fulfill his promises to his people.

Jeremiah 32:18

The Lord always showed his unfailing love, but he also held generations accountable for their sins, and their children faced the consequences. Through his mercy and judgment, the Lord showed his unlimited power. Jeremiah was confident that the Lord would show love to his people as he had promised.

Jeremiah 32:19

The Lord knows what each person does and holds everyone accountable, judging their sins fairly.

Jeremiah 32:20

The Lord performed great miracles in Israel's history, and he was active worldwide. As a result, everyone knew about Israel's God.

Jeremiah 32:21

The first major miracle in Israel's history was the exodus from Egypt. This event was full of powerful signs and wonders. These divine acts caused fear in Egypt and among the desert tribes.

Jeremiah 32:22

God gave Israel the fertile Promised Land.

Jeremiah 32:23

After Israel entered the Promised Land, they soon stopped obeying the Lord. Each generation up to Jeremiah's time rebelled. This long history of sin caused the current disaster. Earlier, Jeremiah struggled to see this act of God as fair, but now he understood that the Lord's word was true.

Jeremiah 32:24

Jeremiah was amazed by the Babylonians' skill. They used ramps to attack the walled city. Inside Jerusalem, he saw war, famine, and disease. It was clear the Babylonians would conquer the city. Jeremiah felt awe as he realized he was witnessing the fulfillment of the Lord's words.

Jeremiah 32:25

Jeremiah was still confused about the Lord's command to buy the field (Jeremiah 32:8). The Babylonian army would control that field, and Jeremiah used his savings to buy it. Since the Lord had said the city would be destroyed, the purchase seemed pointless from a human perspective.

Jeremiah 32:26–27

- The Lord declared that he is the ruler of all the world's people.
- The Lord also asked a rhetorical question to show that nothing is too difficult for him.

Jeremiah 32:26–41

The Lord answered Jeremiah's concern (Jeremiah 32:25) with several affirmations. The Lord had chosen

his plan, set future events, and real doom threatened Jerusalem.

Jeremiah 32:28–29

- The Lord declared that Nebuchadnezzar's army would soon break through the walls. They would capture Jerusalem, and fire would burn everything flammable.
- Baal worship involved families and the entire nation (see Jeremiah 7:17–18). All places used for idol worship, including individual houses, would be destroyed.

Jeremiah 32:30

The people of Israel (the northern tribes) and Judah (the southern tribes) had worshiped idols for centuries, against God's ancient agreement with them. The Lord was very angry about these actions.

Jeremiah 32:30–35

The Lord reaffirmed his plans, explaining that Israel and Judah had done wrong. They turned away from the Lord and made him angry with their sins.

Jeremiah 32:31

This city was built during the reigns of David and Solomon, when Jerusalem became Israel's capital. In the northern kingdom of Israel, every king promoted the worship of false gods. In Judah, only a few kings encouraged worship of the Lord, but their efforts usually did not last (e.g., 2 Chronicles 14:3; 17:6; 29:5; 33:15–16; 34:3, 31–32). The northern kingdom was already destroyed (2 Kings 17:5–12), and now the Lord decided to remove the southern kingdom of Judah (see Deuteronomy 8:19–20).

Jeremiah 32:34–35

The people sinned by defiling God's Temple with terrible idols (Ezekiel 8:3). The leaders of Judah also sacrificed their children to an Ammonite god named Molech (see Jeremiah 7:30–34).

Jeremiah 32:36–37

Jeremiah repeated everything the Lord told him, even if the messages seemed contradictory. For years, Jeremiah said God would destroy the city. Now, he said God would rebuild it. Compare Isaiah 38:1–6.

Jeremiah 32:36–44

The Lord assured that the destruction of Jerusalem would not stop his plans. After the immediate disaster, he planned salvation and restoration for his people.

Jeremiah 32:37

God will bring his people back to Jerusalem, where they will live in peace and safety.

Jeremiah 32:38–40

- The new covenant (Jeremiah 31:31–34) would deeply influence the people's spiritual lives, both individually and as a community.
- They will be My people, and I will be their God: A strong relationship between God and his people would finally happen, as intended by the covenant from the beginning (Jeremiah 7:23; Leviticus 26:12; Ezekiel 11:20; 37:23; Zechariah 8:8).

Jeremiah 32:39

Under the new covenant, people will worship the one true God instead of idols.

Jeremiah 32:41

rejoice: The Lord would no longer be angry at his people for worshiping idols or feel grief for punishing them for breaking the old covenant. He would not uproot them anymore (Jeremiah 1:10); instead, he would find joy in replanting them.

Jeremiah 32:42–43

God's promises for good were as certain as the judgments happening while the Babylonians attacked Jerusalem.

Jeremiah 32:44

fields will be purchased with silver: The Lord directly answered Jeremiah's question (Jeremiah 32:25). Jeremiah signed, sealed, and witnessed a deed for his inherited property (Jeremiah 32:9–11). People would do the same throughout the land of Judah.

Jeremiah 33:1–26

- As Jerusalem and the king of Judah faced invaders, God gave Jeremiah insight into His long-term plan. The promises would only come true after the destruction. The nation's hope was not in avoiding destruction but in the purification it would bring.
- Jeremiah was confined in the courtyard of the guard in the royal palace from late 587 BC, during the siege, until Jerusalem fell in August 586 BC (see Jeremiah 32:2).

Jeremiah 33:2

The Lord based this message on his power as the Creator of everything and the strength of his name.

Jeremiah 33:4

Zedekiah and his men demolished some buildings to strengthen the city's walls against the Babylonians' siege ramps and swords.

Jeremiah 33:5

The men were doomed because the Lord had decided to destroy the city.

Jeremiah 33:8

The Lord promised to cleanse and forgive all their rebellious sins. This promise was the foundation of the new, everlasting covenant (Jeremiah 31:34; 32:38–41).

Jeremiah 33:9

After the new covenant was established, all nations would see the Lord's blessing on Jerusalem.

Jeremiah 33:10–11

Seventy years of exile would come first, but the Lord's curse (Jeremiah 7:34) would be reversed (25:10–12). Singing would mark the restored worship (Psalm 136:1). This prediction came true in 538 to 536 BC when worship in Jerusalem was restored and the foundations of the Second Temple were laid (Ezra 3).

Jeremiah 33:11

bride and bridegroom: Compare the earlier prophecies in Jeremiah 7:34 and 25:10.

Jeremiah 33:12

The Babylonian invasion left the land empty and barren.

Jeremiah 33:14–15

- the days are coming…In those days: These phrases refer to events beyond the return of the exiles, as mentioned by the Lord's prophets (Isaiah 32:1–2). They point to the New Testament fulfillment of God's plan in Jesus Christ, the Good Shepherd (John 10:11) and a righteous branch; Isaiah 4:2; 11:1; Zechariah 3:8; 6:12, 13).
- He: A single person, not a group, would be a fair judge and bring justice with his decisions.

Jeremiah 33:14–18

Continuing the discussion about the flaws in Zedekiah and other kings of David's dynasty (Jeremiah 23:1–5), the Lord revealed the greatness of a future ruler.

Jeremiah 33:16

The LORD Our Righteousness: Hebrew Yahweh Tsidqenu; see Jeremiah 23:5–6, where this title refers to the Messiah. This name reverses Zedekiah's name (Tsidqiyyahu, "Righteous is the Lord"). Zedekiah did not live up to his name, but the Messiah would fulfill it.

Jeremiah 33:17

Zedekiah was the last of David's descendants to rule Judah, but the Messiah, a future descendant of David, will be Israel's king forever.

Jeremiah 33:18

After the exiles returned to Jerusalem, Levitical priests led worship in the new Temple (Ezra 6:13–22).

Jeremiah 33:19–22

Jeremiah shared God's promise. The new agreement with David's descendants and the Levitical priests would be as certain as day following night.

Jeremiah 33:23–26

The Lord had rejected individuals, cities, and kingdoms, but he would never abandon his people, who spanned many generations.

Jeremiah 34:1–7

The Lord encouraged Zedekiah, even though he was a weak and timid leader. The message includes both judgment and a promise.

Jeremiah 34:1–39.18

This section starts with the prediction of Jerusalem's fall and Zedekiah's capture (Jeremiah 34:1–7). The prediction comes true toward the end (Jeremiah 39:1–10). These messages emphasize that the old covenant was broken beyond repair. This was especially true for the kings descended from David, who should have been most dedicated to upholding it.

Jeremiah 34:2

Regardless of King Zedekiah's actions, Jerusalem would fall. The Lord would not save the city.

Jeremiah 34:4–5

Although the Babylonians would defeat Judah, the Lord promised to protect Zedekiah during the war. The king would die peacefully and receive honors from the siege survivors. However, see Jeremiah 39:5–7 for a description of Zedekiah being captured, tortured, and then taken to Babylon.

Jeremiah 34:6–7

King Rehoboam transformed Lachish and Azekah into forts (2 Chronicles 11:5–10). These towns, on low hills southwest of Jerusalem, protected important roads from the coastal highway into Judah's heartland. Archaeologists found military messages on pottery pieces in Lachish's gateway. These messages reported the Babylonians' advance toward the town.

Jeremiah 34:8–22

Zedekiah told the people to free their slaves. He wanted to gain favor with God by following the covenant rules about Hebrew slave ownership (Exodus 21:2–4). These rules had been ignored since the time of Moses. However, the order was useless because the people soon broke this new promise. They had also broken their agreement with Nebuchadnezzar (see Ezekiel 21:23–24) and their original covenant with the Lord. The Lord would punish them for their betrayal.

Jeremiah 34:8–35.19

Here are examples of the faithless (those who break the covenant) (Jeremiah 34:8–22) and the faithful (those who keep the covenant) (35:1–19).

Jeremiah 34:15–16

The slaveholders did the right thing by freeing their slaves; they followed God's command. However, they made their promise in the Temple, and when they broke it, they disrespected God's name and showed contempt (breaking the rule in Deuteronomy 5:11).

Jeremiah 34:17–20

Because they broke their covenant, the Lord would separate them from his protection. This expression refers to a covenant ceremony where they killed and cut a calf into two parts from head to tail. Those making a covenant walked between the pieces to show they agreed to be cut apart if they broke the covenant (see Genesis 15:9–18). All classes of people in Judah broke their oath, so they would all receive the punishment they agreed to.

Jeremiah 34:21–22

Pharaoh Hophra had an agreement with Zedekiah to assist him if attacked (Isaiah 30:1–3; 31:1–3). The Babylonians left Jerusalem to fight against Pharaoh Hophra (Jeremiah 37:5–7), but they returned soon after.

Jeremiah 35:1

This event happened when Jehoiakim was king, during the first Babylonian attack on Jerusalem in 605 BC (see Jeremiah 35:11).

Jeremiah 35:1–19

The Recabites obeyed their ancestor, while the Israelites rebelled against the Lord, their God.

Jeremiah 35:1–36.32

These two chapters reflect on events from twenty years ago when Jehoiakim was king.

Jeremiah 35:2

The Recabites were descendants of Jehonadab, son of Recab, a Kenite who served under Jehu, king of Israel (2 Kings 10:15, 23; 1 Chronicles 2:55). Jeremiah likely knew the Recabites did not drink wine, but he followed the Lord's command.

Jeremiah 35:3

The Jeremiah mentioned here was not the prophet. He and the others were part of the Recabite community.

Jeremiah 35:4

Jeremiah the prophet described the room's location in the Temple. He noted that Hanan, the man in charge, was a man of God. During this idolatrous time in Judah's history, the prophet had friends in high places who still believed in the one true God.

Jeremiah 35:6–10

Jehonadab had required his descendants to live a nomadic life without the comforts of settled living, and the Recabites had obeyed.

Jeremiah 35:12–19

The Lord used the Recabites as a clear contrast to the people of Judah. The Recabites lacked many good things in life, but they stayed obedient.

Jeremiah 35:14–16

The Recabites never drank wine because their ancestor told them not to. The people of Israel should have been even more willing to listen and obey when the Lord told them to turn from their wicked ways and live according to his laws.

Jeremiah 35:17–19

The Lord announced a punishment for Judah's sin.

Jeremiah 35:19

A descendant of Jehonadab, son of Recab, returned from Babylon after the Exile. He helped rebuild the wall of Jerusalem (see Nehemiah 3:14).

Jeremiah 36:1–2

- In 605 BC, during the fourth year of Jehoiakim's reign, Nebuchadnezzar first attacked Jerusalem (see study note on Daniel 1:1).
- In those days, a scroll was a roll made of papyrus or leather strips joined edge to edge and rolled up.

Jeremiah 36:1–32

- This description of Jehoiakim's cynical response to God's call for repentance and obedience (Jeremiah 36:3, 7) highlights the hopelessness of the situation.
- Nowhere else does the Old Testament offer such detailed information about preserving spoken messages in written form.

Jeremiah 36:3

The Lord gave the people of Judah many chances to repent. God wanted the messages of judgment to not only alarm them but also to make them aware of the consequences of idol worship. If they listened to the warning, repented, and sincerely worshiped the one true God, he would forgive their sins and wrongdoings.

Jeremiah 36:4

Jeremiah was not skilled in writing, so he hired a scribe named Baruch. In their private quarters, Jeremiah recited messages from memory. It is unclear if Baruch helped with the composition or arrangement, or if he just wrote down exactly what Jeremiah said.

Jeremiah 36:5

Jeremiah was either a prisoner under house arrest or banished from the Temple grounds.

Jeremiah 36:6

The next day of fasting was a national festival, but it is unclear which one (none of the annual festivals happened in the ninth month; see study note on Jeremiah 36:8–9). Reading the scroll to the crowd in the Temple put Baruch at risk of arrest or attack.

Jeremiah 36:7

- Jeremiah explained why he wrote the scroll (Jeremiah 36:3) and read it to the public.
- Perhaps...each one will turn from his wicked way: The people could still receive the Lord's forgiveness and avoid his anger.

Jeremiah 36:8–9

Baruch wrote Jeremiah's messages from the Lord on the scroll. A day of fasting was announced near the end of 604 BC. Baruch followed Jeremiah's order to read the scroll in the Temple, where many people gathered in the courtyard.

Jeremiah 36:10

- From the chamber of Gemariah...Baruch read: Baruch got permission from this high official to read to the public. This elevated spot near the New Gate entrance was close to where Jeremiah's public trial had happened a few years earlier (Jeremiah 26:10).
- Gemariah had a godly heritage. His father, Shaphan, took part in Josiah's reading of the scrolls found in the Temple (2 Kings 22:8–10).

Jeremiah 36:11–13

Micaiah understood the importance of the Lord's messages that Baruch read. He ensured the palace officials knew what was said.

Jeremiah 36:14–16

The palace officials acted quickly. When they heard Baruch reading Jeremiah's messages, they became frightened and decided to inform the king.

Jeremiah 36:17–18

The officials wanted to learn where the scroll came from and what its messages meant.

Jeremiah 36:19–20

The officials respected Jeremiah and Baruch by advising them to hide. They respected the Lord's messages by safely storing the scroll before informing the king.

Jeremiah 36:21

Jehudi was well educated and might have been a scribe. Only the elite learned to read and write.

Jeremiah 36:23–24

Jehoiakim was so hostile and stubborn that after hearing three or four columns of the scroll, he cut off the section with a sharp knife and threw it into the fire. Jehoiakim's father, Josiah, reacted very differently when he heard the newly discovered Book of the Law (2 Kings 22:11).

Jeremiah 36:25

The three officials who asked the king not to destroy the scroll likely held powerful positions. Jehoiakim did not punish them for trying to save Jeremiah's scroll.

Jeremiah 36:26

After the Lord hid them, no one revealed Jeremiah and Baruch's location. The Lord can protect his servants.

Jeremiah 36:27–32

While hiding, Jeremiah and Baruch copied all the messages from the destroyed scroll onto a new papyrus roll. No human king can destroy God's words. Instead, God sentenced Jehoiakim to death.

Jeremiah 36:29–31

To die without heirs or a proper burial was considered the worst fate (see Jeremiah 22:19; Ecclesiastes 6:3). Jehoiakim's son, Jehoiachin, ruled for only three months. Unlike his father, Jehoiachin heeded Jeremiah's warning and surrendered to the Babylonians. They took him and others to Babylon as captives (Jeremiah 22:24–30; 2 Kings 24:8–16).

Jeremiah 37:1–2

These verses summarize Zedekiah's rule and how he responded to the Lord's messages through Jeremiah.

Jeremiah 37:1–38.28

The focus now returns to Zedekiah, who became king of Judah after his nephew Jehoiachin. These chapters describe meetings between Zedekiah and Jeremiah, highlighting Zedekiah's struggle to fully commit to God's word (compare Deuteronomy 10:12–13). Zedekiah is a classic example of a person with divided loyalty (James 1:6–8).

Jeremiah 37:3–4

Zedekiah asked for prayer, hoping Jeremiah's prayers would magically defeat the enemy (see Jeremiah 14:7–9 and Jeremiah 14:7–9).

Jeremiah 37:5

The Babylonians started their siege of Jerusalem in 588 BC. However, they left because Pharaoh Hophra's army was coming to help Judah. The Babylonians aimed to stop and defeat the Egyptians, and they succeeded.

Jeremiah 37:6–10

The Lord answered Jeremiah's prayer (Jeremiah 37:3) with a warning for Zedekiah. The Egyptians would not offer lasting help, and the Babylonians would return to destroy Jerusalem. This prophecy came true in 586 BC.

Jeremiah 37:11–12

When the Babylonians went to face the Egyptians, Jeremiah walked three miles north to his hometown, Anathoth. He wanted to claim his share of the property among his relatives and see his newly purchased land (Jeremiah 32:1–25).

Jeremiah 37:13–16

The guards and other officials of Judah misunderstood Jeremiah's actions and thought he was deserting.

Jeremiah 37:17

The king asked Jeremiah about other messages from the Lord, showing his fear of the future. He still hoped the Lord would defeat the Babylonians. Jeremiah quickly and firmly said there was no hope for divine intervention like the one that destroyed the Assyrian army during Hezekiah's reign (2 Kings 19:8–37).

Jeremiah 37:18–20

Jeremiah likely thought Zedekiah was behind his arrest and imprisonment. The prophet was probably in poor health after being whipped and held without medical care and with little food.

Jeremiah 37:21

The king went against his officials and told the guards to keep Jeremiah in the palace courtyard under protective watch. During the long siege, food was scarce, so a fresh loaf of bread each day was a generous amount.

Jeremiah 38:1

- The Gedaliah mentioned here had a different father than the Gedaliah in Jeremiah 40:6.
- The first Pashhur might have been the man in Jeremiah 20:1. The second Pashhur had a different father.

Jeremiah 38:1–13

Jeremiah could talk to people while in the prison courtyard. He shared the Lord's judgments, which angered some government officials. Zedekiah showed cowardice by allowing these men to put Jeremiah in a muddy cistern. However, the king showed courage

when he let a palace servant rescue Jeremiah and bring him back to the palace prison.

Jeremiah 38:4

The officials thought Jeremiah's prophecies would lower the soldiers' morale against the Babylonian army. So, they put him on trial for treason.

Jeremiah 38:5

The officials angrily confronted King Zedekiah and made their demands. He was weak and afraid.

Jeremiah 38:6

In front of everyone in the palace courtyard, they threw Jeremiah into an empty cistern. A thick layer of mud at the bottom slowly covered his body.

Jeremiah 38:7–8

The Ethiopian (compare Luke 17:18; Acts 28:28): Jeremiah's rescuer was not from Judah. He was a foreigner who bravely opposed the other officials. He ran to the Benjamin Gate, where they first arrested Jeremiah (Jeremiah 37:11–13), and entered the king's presence without ceremony.

Jeremiah 38:10

The rescue party included thirty men, perhaps showing that Zedekiah wanted to prevent his officials from attacking it.

Jeremiah 38:11–12

Ebed-melech, the Ethiopian rescuer (Jeremiah 38:7), was a compassionate person who wanted to protect Jeremiah's frail body as much as possible.

Jeremiah 38:14

The location of the third entrance to the Lord's Temple is unknown. The Temple gates had small rooms nearby, so the private meeting likely occurred in one of these rooms.

Jeremiah 38:14–16

Zedekiah desperately wanted a miracle to save his kingdom from the Babylonian armies. He arranged a secret meeting with Jeremiah.

Jeremiah 38:17–18

Jeremiah explained the Lord's command. Zedekiah could save the city by surrendering, or he could see it destroyed by the invaders.

Jeremiah 38:19

Zedekiah feared his fellow countrymen who had defected more than he feared the Lord or the Babylonians. Therefore, he ignored Jeremiah's advice. This was Jeremiah's final message to the king.

Jeremiah 38:20–22

Jeremiah told Zedekiah that things would be fine if he obeyed the Lord. If he did not, even his friends would leave him.

Jeremiah 38:24–28

- When Zedekiah feared his officials again, he demanded that Jeremiah keep secret what he had told him.
- The officials might have suspected that Zedekiah planned to surrender to the enemy. Jeremiah obeyed the king's order to stay silent, and he spent the final days of the siege in the palace prison under the king's protection.

Jeremiah 39:1–10

As Jeremiah had predicted (Jeremiah 34:1–7), the Lord judged Zedekiah and the kingdom of Judah. For more details on this event, see Jeremiah 52:4–16; 2 Kings 25:1–21; 2 Chronicles 36:11–21; Ezekiel 24:1–14.

Jeremiah 39:2

The Babylonian siege lasted a long time because Jerusalem's stone walls were thick and the people resisted strongly.

Jeremiah 39:3

High-ranking officers entered the city to oversee its destruction and sat triumphantly at the Middle Gate, showing the victory's importance to the Babylonians. Victorious officials traditionally positioned themselves at a gate, as gateways controlled judicial and administrative matters.

Jeremiah 39:4

The steep slopes of the Kidron Valley on the east and the Ben-Hinnom Valley on the west and south of Jerusalem forced the Babylonian army to focus their forces to the north. This allowed Zedekiah, his family, and his officials to escape from the south end of the city. They crossed the Kidron Valley and traveled over the Mount of Olives. Although they left after nightfall, the noise of their departure alerted Babylonian sentries, and soldiers soon chased them.

Jeremiah 39:5

Zedekiah and his royal group fled on foot. Strong and healthy soldiers easily captured them near Jericho. The enemy troops then forced the captives to walk over 200 miles north to Riblah, where King Nebuchadnezzar had his field headquarters.

Jeremiah 39:6

Zedekiah's last sight was the killing of his sons and all the nobles of Judah. This ensured that Zedekiah's rule could not continue.

Jeremiah 39:7

After Nebuchadnezzar gouged out Zedekiah's eyes, Zedekiah walked 400 miles to Babylon, blind, in great pain, and with his arms in bronze chains.

Jeremiah 39:9

carried away to Babylon the remnant of the people: They usually tied each person's hands and connected them to the person in front, forming a long line of sad captives.

Jeremiah 39:11–14

We do not fully know how Nebuchadnezzar learned about Jeremiah urging the king to surrender to Babylon. Perhaps Jeremiah's messages to the exiles (Jeremiah 29; see 40:2–3) reached him.

Jeremiah 39:11–44.30

These chapters describe what happened after Jerusalem's destruction, focusing on how it impacted Jeremiah.

Jeremiah 39:15–17

Ebed-melech saved Jeremiah from dying in the muddy cistern (Jeremiah 38:7–13). This promise was a serious declaration (see study note on Jeremiah 2:2).

Jeremiah 40:1–6

This passage explains what happened to Jeremiah right after Jerusalem fell.

Jeremiah 40:2–3

The guard captain mentioned that the Lord's prediction through Jeremiah had come true.

Jeremiah 40:6

Gedaliah set up his new headquarters in Mizpah, which is eight miles north of the destroyed Jerusalem.

Jeremiah 40:7–8

News quickly spread among the Judean guerrilla groups and the poor people left behind about Gedaliah's appointment as governor. A small group of guerrilla leaders arranged to meet with Gedaliah to understand his plans better.

Jeremiah 40:7–12

The new government was organized under Gedaliah, who came from a high-ranking family. His grandfather, Shaphan, had given King Josiah the scroll of the law that started a reformation (2 Kings 22:10). Gedaliah's father, Ahikam, held a high position among Jehoiakim's officials and saved Jeremiah's life (Jeremiah 26:24).

Jeremiah 40:9–10

Gedaliah tried to convince the Judean fighters that living peacefully under Babylonian rule would lead to prosperity.

Jeremiah 40:11–12

The new governor's promises encouraged the people of Judah, who had fled to nearby countries, to return to their land. The mention of a great harvest shows that the Babylonians did not destroy the crops when they attacked Jerusalem.

Jeremiah 40:14

- Ammon was a small highland nation east of the Jordan Valley.
- Ishmael, son of Nethaniah, was of royal descent (2 Kings 25:25).

Jeremiah 40:16

Gedaliah's response showed his naivety and the distrust in advisers that affected the entire chaotic situation.

Jeremiah 41:1–2

- In the seventh month: These events happened three months after Jerusalem fell.
- they ate a meal together there: Ishmael's attack cruelly broke Gedaliah's hospitality.

Jeremiah 41:4–5

The murderers kept their crime secret until the next day. Men from Shechem, Shiloh, and Samaria, located to the north, arrived as they traveled south to the ruins of Jerusalem. Their appearance and the offerings they carried showed they were seeking mercy from

the Lord (Leviticus 2:1; 14:2–9). The annual Festival of Shelters took place at this time of year at the Temple (Leviticus 23:33–36), and the eighty worshipers were likely unarmed.

Jeremiah 41:8

The ten men who survived acted quickly and saved their lives by promising to give Ishmael's men what they needed most: wheat, barley, olive oil, and honey.

Jeremiah 41:9

a large one that King Asa had made: See 2 Chronicles 16:1–6. That passage does not mention cisterns, but storing water and grain would have needed them. Several cisterns have been found in the city's ruins.

Jeremiah 41:10

Some of the king's daughters managed to avoid being killed or taken into exile.

Jeremiah 41:11–12

Johanan and his companions heard about Gedaliah's death in time to attack Ishmael's group at the pool near Gibeon, a few miles south of Mizpah.

Jeremiah 41:16

Johanan was with many important people, such as:

- Soldiers
- Women
- Children
- Court officials

Jeremiah 41:17–18

The group led by Johanan traveled south, past the ruins of Jerusalem, to Geruth-kimham, a small village near Bethlehem. During this journey, the leaders decided they would be safer from Babylonian revenge if they fled to Egypt. The Babylonians were cruel, and no one trusted them to find the real person responsible for Gedaliah's death.

Jeremiah 42:1–3

The group of Judean fighters and the people they had saved (Jeremiah 41:16) approached Jeremiah with a request for guidance that seemed sincere.

Jeremiah 42:4

The phrase I have heard you shows that Jeremiah doubted the sincerity of the Judean group led by Johanan. However, the prophet agreed to pray for divine guidance and to share the complete message of the Lord's answer with them.

Jeremiah 42:5–6

These people might have sensed that Jeremiah doubted their sincerity. They responded by making a serious promise. They committed to obey the Lord's instructions and agreed to accept punishment if they broke the promise. They felt sure that the Lord's answer would be what they wanted to hear.

Jeremiah 42:10–12

- The Lord said he wanted the people to remain in Judea and settle there. He promised to establish them in the land (see Jeremiah 1:10). Judea's time of judgment had ended.
- I am with you to save you: The Lord urged the remaining people of Judea to trust him for protection from the king of Babylon.

Jeremiah 42:13–22

Jeremiah had already predicted Egypt's fate; the Babylonians would destroy it (Jeremiah 46:2–26). This remaining group from Judah would face the Lord's judgment if they went to Egypt.

Jeremiah 42:21

Like their ancestors, this group from Judah relied on the Egyptians for protection instead of trusting in the Lord.

Jeremiah 43:1–7

Johanan and the others broke their promise (Jeremiah 42:20) when they decided not to trust the Lord's message through Jeremiah.

Jeremiah 43:3

The reason Baruch was blamed is unknown.

Jeremiah 43:7

The city of Tahpanhes (Jeremiah 2:16; Ezekiel 30:18), now called Tell Dafneh, protected the road entering Egypt at its northeast corner.

Jeremiah 43:10

Nebuchadnezzar: Compare Jeremiah 42:2–22; Ezekiel 29:19–20. An Akkadian inscription states that Nebuchadnezzar invaded Egypt in 568 to 567 BC, less than twenty years after Jeremiah's message.

Jeremiah 43:12–13

In the ancient Near East, people saw temples and idols as power centers. Successful invaders usually destroyed them.

Jeremiah 43:13

- The ancient Egyptians greatly valued the sacred pillars.
- In the temple of the sun, or in Heliopolis, the sun was the main god of their religion. The ruins of this city are about six miles northeast of modern Cairo.

Jeremiah 44:1

After arriving in Egypt, the refugees from Judah spread across the country. Migdol was a fortress near Tahpanhes in northeastern Egypt. Memphis was the first capital of Egypt. It became the religious center of northern Egypt. Its ruins are on the west side of the Nile River, about thirteen miles southwest of Cairo. Some refugees had already moved to southern Egypt, following the Nile River upstream.

Jeremiah 44:2

Jeremiah's message connected with the shared understanding of the disaster that destroyed Judah and Jerusalem.

Jeremiah 44:3

Since the Exodus, Israel has forbidden the worship of false gods.

Jeremiah 44:9

These Judean refugees did not learn from their past. They forgot their previous mistakes and how God judged them.

Jeremiah 44:11

The Lord declared a death sentence, using the power of his own name.

Jeremiah 44:12

Unlike those exiled to Babylon, to whom the Lord had given hope (see Jeremiah 33:7–18; Ezekiel 34:12–15; 36:24–31), this remnant of Judah had no future.

Jeremiah 44:15

This group of Judeans likely gathered to watch a non-Jewish festival.

Jeremiah 44:15–19

The people rejected Jeremiah's warning of judgment. They had stopped even pretending to serve the Lord (Jeremiah 42:1–3) and were fully devoted to idol worship.

Jeremiah 44:17

- The Judean refugees thought they had freedom. They believed obeying the Lord meant being in bondage, while pagan worship led to fulfillment.
- The Queen of Heaven had many names across the ancient Near East. In Assyria and Babylon, she was "Ishtar," and the Canaanites called her "Astarte." In the Old Testament, she is often "Ashtoreth" and linked with Baal. Solomon worshiped Ashtoreth and built shrines for her, but Josiah later destroyed them (2 Kings 23:13; see 1 Kings 11:5). Ashtoreth was connected to the planet Venus and all types of reproduction in plants and animals, making her a popular idol for farmers and herdsmen. People believed offerings of incense, food, and liquids would magically trigger reproduction and prosperity.

Jeremiah 44:18

These Judeans believed that worshiping the Queen of Heaven brought prosperity. They thought stopping this worship would lead to war and famine (see Hosea 2:8). Their beliefs were entirely pagan.

Jeremiah 44:20–23

The destruction of Judah and Jerusalem was not because the Lord could not provide prosperity. Instead, he could no longer tolerate the people's disgusting actions.

Jeremiah 44:20–30

This group of Judeans in Egypt had cut ties with the one true God of Israel, leading to their condemnation to death.

Jeremiah 44:24–25

The Lord allowed the people to serve the Queen of Heaven, and they would face the results of their choice (compare Romans 1:24, 28).

Jeremiah 44:26–28

The Judeans in Egypt were now free from their covenant obligations to the Lord. However, they also lost covenant protection. By choosing to end their relationship with the God of Israel, they gave up all privileges. They could not pray or make oaths in God's name. Still, the Lord would not be absent from their

lives, as he would ensure that disaster affected them. Those who turned to the Lord in repentance would receive salvation and blessings. Even in Egypt, a small group of people, like Jeremiah and Baruch, trusted in the Lord.

Jeremiah 44:30

- Pharaoh Hophra was killed by his enemies in Egypt in 570 BC.
- This verse ends the account of Jeremiah's forty-year ministry. We do not know where, when, or how Jeremiah died.

Jeremiah 45:1

This event happened in the same year Baruch spent many hours in hiding. There, he wrote the messages the Lord gave to Jeremiah (Jeremiah 36:1–4).

Jeremiah 45:1–5

This chapter takes place in 605 BC, over twenty years before the previous chapters. Jeremiah's secretary, Baruch, felt overwhelmed with problems. The Lord promised him safety.

Jeremiah 45:3

Jehoiakim had threatened to kill both Jeremiah and Baruch, so the prophet and the scribe went into hiding. Baruch was very tired and felt sorry for himself.

Jeremiah 45:5

Baruch could rely on divine protection, regardless of the troubles he faced. The chapters before this one show that the Lord kept this promise. Baruch was with Jeremiah when they went to Egypt.

Jeremiah 46:1–51.64

This series of messages is aimed at foreign nations (see Jeremiah 1:5, 10, and similar messages in Isaiah 13–23; Ezekiel 25–32; Amos 1:3–2:3).

Through Nebuchadnezzar, the Lord planned to judge all nations from the Euphrates River to Egypt for their rebellion and sins against him (compare Leviticus 18:24–25). Eventually, Babylon would also face God's judgment (Jeremiah 50–51). These chapters were likely written while Jeremiah and Baruch were in hiding (Jeremiah 36:27–32). Among the warnings of doom for the foreign nations' sins are a few statements offering hope for salvation. Collections of oracles against the nations are also found in Isaiah (Isaiah 13–23) and Ezekiel (Ezekiel 25–32). Although God used nearby nations to punish his rebellious people, he also held those nations accountable for their actions. The Lord is not only the God of Israel; he is the God of the entire world.

Jeremiah 46:2–12

Jeremiah used the outcome of a battle known to Jehoiakim to warn him and the people of Jerusalem. He said Egypt could not protect them from Babylon. Pharaoh Neco believed it was the right time to become the main power in the ancient Near East, so he moved north in 609 BC. Neco spent several years helping parts of the Assyrian army try to stop the Babylonian army's westward advance. However, he was defeated at Carchemish on the Euphrates River in 605 BC. Soon after, the Babylonian army surrounded Jerusalem and forced Jehoiakim to become a Babylonian vassal.

Jeremiah 46:3–4

Leaders gave these military commands when soldiers were excited, well-armed, and ready to fight.

Jeremiah 46:7–8

Despite Pharaoh Neco's boasting and his soldiers' intimidating presence, his tactics neither confused the enemy nor won the battle (compare 1 Kings 20:11).

Jeremiah 46:9–10

The Lord decided that Egypt would lose the battle, so allies would not help much. The Battle of Carchemish was crucial for Babylon's rise as the region's great empire.

Jeremiah 46:11

Gilead was famous for its healing plants (compare Jeremiah 8:22).

Jeremiah 46:13–24

The defeat at Carchemish caused chaos in Egypt and its armies. The Lord was judging Egypt.

Jeremiah 46:15–17

The Lord made the Egyptian soldiers afraid, and they could not stay organized as they fled from Carchemish through Canaan to their homes in Egypt. Back in Egypt, they strongly criticized Pharaoh Neco, calling him a loudmouth.

Jeremiah 46:18

Mount Tabor stands tall in the eastern part of the Jezreel Valley. Mount Carmel rises above the Mediterranean Sea's coastline.

Jeremiah 46:19

Memphis will be laid waste: This happened in 568 and 567 BC when Nebuchadnezzar invaded Egypt.

Jeremiah 46:21

Egypt relied on mercenaries from other countries who did not want to die for Egypt. When threatened, they would flee.

Jeremiah 46:22–23

The image of a serpent slithering away shows the fear that took over Egypt. The invaders attacked the people fiercely, like woodsmen chopping wood, after entering the country like a swarm of locusts.

Jeremiah 46:25–26

- Amon was a fertility god worshiped in Thebes, the capital of Southern Egypt. Amon's idol, shaped like a ram, symbolized the sun. The Egyptians believed this god was very powerful. However, like all other Egyptian deities, it would be destroyed by the all-powerful God of Israel. The Pharaoh, who claimed to be the son of the sun-god, would face the same fate.
- Egypt will be inhabited: In 601 BC, Nebuchadnezzar attacked Egypt, caused great damage, and then withdrew. He invaded the land again in 568 to 567 BC (Jeremiah 43:8–13; Ezekiel 29:19).

Jeremiah 46:27

I will surely save you out of a distant place: The exiles started returning to Judea in 538 BC. Israel faced discipline but was not destroyed.

Jeremiah 47:1–7

This message from the Lord was about the Philistine cities on the southeastern coast of the Mediterranean Sea and their allies to the north. The Lord decided these cities would be destroyed during the Babylonian invasion.

Jeremiah 47:2

an overflowing torrent: This metaphor describes the Babylonian armies moving into the coastal area. This began in 609 BC and peaked in 605 BC (compare Jeremiah 1:11–14).

Jeremiah 47:4

- For the day has come to destroy: The Lord decided what would happen and when events would occur.
- The Philistines arrived in the southeastern coastal areas from the island of Crete between 1200 and 1100 BC. The northern cities, Tyre and Sidon, were colonized around the same time by distant relatives of the Philistines who mixed with the native Canaanites.

Jeremiah 47:5

- Gaza was a major Philistine city.
- shave their heads: The people expressed their grief by shaving their heads (compare Isaiah 15:2; Micah 1:16).
- Ashkelon, another Philistine city a few miles north on the coast, would become empty.

Jeremiah 47:6

O sword of the LORD: God used the Babylonians to carry out his justice. This request might have come from the Philistine cities under attack by the Babylonians. The people wanted the attacks to stop.

Jeremiah 47:7

The punishment would continue for a while. The judge had made his decision, and his mission was clear: Ashkelon must be destroyed.

Jeremiah 48:1

- The powerful Judge, the God of Israel (see study note on Jeremiah 2:2), presented the charges and decisions against Moab.
- The city of Nebo was located on the side of Mount Nebo (Numbers 32:3, 38), several miles east of the northern end of the Dead Sea.
- The tribe of Reuben built the city of Kiriathaim (Joshua 13:19) in the highlands east of the Dead Sea.

Jeremiah 48:1–47

Moab, one of two nations descended from Abraham's nephew Lot (Genesis 19:36–38), was the next nation judged in the Lord's courtroom (compare Isaiah 15–16). Moab's land was between the Arnon River and the Zered Brook, east of the Dead Sea. At that time, the Moabites felt confident because they were mostly safe from Babylonian military power. However, the Lord found the Moabites to be greedy and cruel, and their worship was violent and indulgent.

Jeremiah 48:1–49.6

The Lord ordered the destruction and future rebuilding of Moab and Ammon. These two nations came from Lot, who was Abraham's nephew (Genesis 19:36–38).

Jeremiah 48:2

- Heshbon was between the Jabbok and Arnon rivers, east of the Dead Sea.
- Madmen was likely another name for Dibon, a town near Heshbon. It would also be destroyed.

Jeremiah 48:3–4

We know little about the village of Horonaim (see Isaiah 15:5). It was likely near the southeastern shore of the Dead Sea.

Jeremiah 48:5–6

Luhith was another small village near Horonaim. The sadness from oppression would touch even the smallest places.

Jeremiah 48:7

The people of Moab boasted about their wealth and skill. However, their biggest sin was worshiping a deity named Chemosh. This false god symbolized the magical power of reproduction, but it would soon become clear that Chemosh was powerless.

Jeremiah 48:8–10

The Lord ordered the destruction of all the towns in Moab. He instructed his agents to carry out his command faithfully.

Jeremiah 48:11–12

Moab enjoyed a long history of peace and a culture its people valued greatly. Moab had many vineyards. After squeezing the grape juice, they stored the wine in clay flasks until it became fragrant and smooth.

Jeremiah 48:13

- The Lord's judgment would make the Moabites embarrassed that Chemosh could not protect them. This is similar to how the Israelites of the northern kingdom felt when the false gods they worshiped could not protect them from the Assyrians (1 Kings 12:28–29; 13:33–34; Hosea 8:5–6).
- ashamed when they trusted in Bethel: See 1 Kings 12:28–30.

Jeremiah 48:18–19

Dibon and nearby Aroer were important cities in Moab.

Jeremiah 48:20

When people heard that Moab was in ruins, panic quickly spread in the Arnon Valley.

Jeremiah 48:21–25

Eleven Moabite villages would soon learn that Moab's military strength was broken. This meant the villages had no defense against the advancing enemy.

Jeremiah 48:26–27

Moab hated Israel because they opposed the Lord.

Jeremiah 48:31

- The Lord punished Moab and other nations for their sins, but this made him mourn.
- Kir-hareseth was the capital city of Moab.

Jeremiah 48:32

The tribe of Reuben conquered and rebuilt Sibmah and Jazer (Numbers 32:3, 38; Joshua 13:19). They turned the high plateau east of the Dead Sea into vineyards.

Jeremiah 48:34–39

- These verses describe the impact of the Lord's judgment on the Moabite people.
- The Moabite towns mentioned were along small rivers flowing east into the Dead Sea.

Jeremiah 48:35–37

The Moabites showed their sorrow and grief through traditional actions. They shaved their heads and beards, cut their hands, and wore burlap clothing (Jeremiah 41:5; Job 1:20).

Jeremiah 48:39

The Lord's judgment of Moab would make nearby countries realize they could face similar ruin as punishment.

Jeremiah 48:40

The eagle symbolizes speed and surprise. It catches its prey and carries it away before the prey can react.

Jeremiah 48:43–45

The people of Moab could not escape the terror (Hebrew pakhad), traps (Hebrew pakhath), and snares (Hebrew pakh).

Jeremiah 48:45

- If the Moabites fled north, they would meet their enemies at Heshbon.
- fire has gone forth from Heshbon: (compare Numbers 21:28).

Jeremiah 48:47

The Lord promised to show mercy to Moab. He said the people would prosper in the future.

Jeremiah 49:1

- After the northern kingdom of Israel fell in 722 BC, the Ammonites moved into land left by the tribe of Gad.
- The Ammonites worshiped a fertility god named Molech, meaning "ruler," similar to Baal, meaning "master."

Jeremiah 49:1–6

Ammon was the next nation judged in the Lord's courtroom. Ammon was the second descendant of Lot (see study note on Jeremiah 48:1–47). Its land was north of Moab and east of Israel. Ammon's destruction happened soon after Jerusalem fell.

Jeremiah 49:2

Rabbah, the capital of Ammon, was destroyed in 582 BC.

Jeremiah 49:3

The Ammonites might have believed their deity, Molech, was powerful. However, the invader would take this idol, along with its priests and officials, into exile. Their ritual magic would be revealed as fake.

Jeremiah 49:4–6

The Ammonites relied on their wealth, but it could not keep them safe. The Lord ensured their judgment and future restoration.

Jeremiah 49:7–8

- Is there no longer wisdom: Edom was known for its wise men, but they would soon seem foolish because they did not know about the coming disaster.
- Teman and Dedan were cities in Edom.

Jeremiah 49:7–22

The people of Edom were descendants of Esau, Jacob's brother (Genesis 32:3). Edom was located south of Moab, in the highlands east of the Arabah Valley. The divine Judge held every nation accountable.

Jeremiah 49:9–11

Harvesters usually left some of the crop for the poor (Leviticus 19:9–10). Thieves would take only the grapes they could grab quickly and easily. The invaders would take their time and ruthlessly strip Edom bare, leaving only ruin behind. However, the Lord promised to show mercy to the defeated nation's orphans and widows.

Jeremiah 49:12–22

The cup of judgment represented the fulfillment of the Lord's commands (see Jeremiah 25:15–17). This part clearly shows what happens after a nation drinks from that cup.

Jeremiah 49:13

Bozrah was a fortress on a high, steep rock, but nowhere in Edom was safe.

Jeremiah 49:14

The ambassador could have been an angel sent by God (compare 1 Kings 22:20–22).

Jeremiah 49:15–16

- The leaders of Edom believed they were powerful because they scared travelers on the King's Highway.
- Edom had a rock fortress, now called Petra. It was difficult to find and reachable only through a deep, narrow gorge. Even this remote place could not protect the Edomites from the Lord's judgment.

Jeremiah 49:18

Like the destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah, Edom would become empty of people.

Jeremiah 49:19

- In divine judgment, the Lord would use the Babylonians to come like a lion, leaping on the sheep as they chased Edom's leaders out of the land.
- The Lord's rhetorical questions implied the answer, "No one can challenge the Lord; he is the only Almighty ruler."

Jeremiah 49:22

The eagle, a common bird in Edom's rugged mountains, symbolizes how quickly the Babylonians entered the region.

Jeremiah 49:23–27

Damascus, the capital of Aram (ancient Syria), and the Aramean cities of Hamath and Arpad, show that Aram is the next target of the Lord's judgment.

Jeremiah 49:25

Damascus has a long history of power and glory as a center of major trade routes. Its people enjoyed

prosperity and happiness. However, they lost these pleasures when the Lord abandoned them.

Jeremiah 49:27

- The city's walls and palaces were likely built with wood from Mount Hermon's slopes.
- Ben-hadad, meaning son of the mighty one, was the royal title for many Aramean kings.

Jeremiah 49:28–29

The Babylonians aimed to defeat the Kedar warriors to seize their valuable household goods and camels.

Jeremiah 49:28–33

- The nomads of Kedar moved freely in the upper Arabian Desert, east of Palestine. They were a warlike people (Psalm 120:5–7; Isaiah 21:13–16) who raised animals for profitable trade with Tyre (Ezekiel 27:21).
- Hazor was a region east of Damascus where nomads lived.
- The poem encourages King Nebuchadnezzar to attack and describes the battles' effects.

Jeremiah 49:30

The Lord urged the people of Hazor to flee and hide, even though it would not help them. Nebuchadnezzar, the Babylonian king, planned to conquer them.

Jeremiah 49:34–39

The last poetic message in this series was for Elam. This fierce nation was in the Zagros Mountains, far east of Babylon (Ezekiel 32:24).

Jeremiah 49:35

The Elamite warriors were expert archers, but their skills did not save Elam.

Jeremiah 49:36

After a successful invasion, the victors often scattered the refugees across a wide area.

Jeremiah 49:37

The Lord would show his strong anger through the great disaster coming to Elam. Although no specific charge is mentioned, Elam, like other nations, worshipped false gods and was cruel in wars against its neighbors.

Jeremiah 49:38

I will set My throne in Elam: The Lord will show his supreme authority by removing Elam's king and officials.

Jeremiah 49:39

The Lord's judgment included a promise to restore Elam's fortunes. In 539 BC, Cyrus, an Elam native, conquered Babylon and started the Persian Empire. Susa, Elam's former capital, became the Persian Empire's capital (Esther 1:2). God chose Cyrus to free the Jews (Isaiah 44:28–45:1).

Jeremiah 50:1–51.64

This message of judgment on Babylon is the longest for any nation except Judah. It mixes threats against Babylon with promises to restore Judah. Babylon acted as the Lord's agent to destroy other Near Eastern civilizations. However, Babylon was also guilty of its own sins. The Lord would judge Babylon by making her experience what she did to others (Jeremiah 50:15).

Jeremiah 50:2

- Raising a signal flag was a popular way to warn that an enemy was nearing a city (compare Isaiah 13:2).
- The people of Babylon would face divine judgment because they worshiped the gods Bel (the Babylonian name for Baal) and Marduk (the Babylonian god of wind, storm, and fertility).

Jeremiah 50:3

The nation from the north was Persia, led by Cyrus in 539 BC. Persia was east of Babylon. It first attacked Babylonia in the north and then moved south. The attack destroyed the powerful Babylonian Empire.

Jeremiah 50:4

In those days: In 538, 458, and 445 BC, some exiles from Israel returned to their homeland.

The people of Israel and Judah would come back, crying with joy and repentance. They chose to worship the Lord their God instead of idols.

Jeremiah 50:4–10

This poem gave hope to the Israelite exiles in Babylon. It contrasted with the judgment and oppression they faced. The divine Judge is also the divine Savior.

Jeremiah 50:5

an everlasting covenant: See Jeremiah 31:23–34.

Jeremiah 50:6

- The leaders of Israel and Judah, like Jeroboam I and Manasseh (see 1 Kings 12:25–13:34; 2 Kings 21:1–18), led the people away from the Lord.
- The mountains were both literal and symbolic—people often worshipped Baal on high places.

Jeremiah 50:7

This verse continues the metaphor of lost sheep (Jeremiah 50:6), linking Israel's vulnerability to attack with their turning away from the Lord. Their enemies justified mistreating Israel by claiming the Israelites had sinned against the Lord. These enemies knew that the Israelites' true place of rest and hope was with the Lord.

Jeremiah 50:8–9

The Lord told the Israelites to leave when he commanded a large army from many nations, including Persia and its allies, to attack Babylon in 539 BC.

Jeremiah 50:11

rejoice...frolic: The Babylonians were happy and carefree because they had taken from the Lord's people in Jerusalem. They did not care about the well-being of those they conquered.

Jeremiah 50:11–16

These verses vividly describe the defeat of Babylon by the Persian invasion (see Jeremiah 51; Isaiah 13:14; 21:1–10; 44:28; 47:1–5; Daniel 5). Babylon never became an important kingdom again. The city was destroyed in 485 BC. Archaeologists began excavating Babylon in 1899, uncovering its remains over several decades.

Jeremiah 50:12

The divine Judge gave his decision, describing the shame of a defeated Babylon.

Jeremiah 50:14

- The Lord commanded armies to attack Babylon with many arrows, the artillery of that time.
- she has sinned against the LORD: The main accusation against other nations was also aimed at Babylon.

Jeremiah 50:15

The Lord's judgment was fulfilled when Babylon surrendered and its walls fell. The Lord's vengeance delivered justice by doing to Babylon what it had done to others (compare Deuteronomy 19:21; Luke 6:38).

Jeremiah 50:16

When Babylon fell, farmers left their crops and fled. The battle's violence made people escape.

Jeremiah 50:17

Assyria took over the northern kingdom of Israel between 734 and 722 BC. Nebuchadnezzar took over the southern kingdom of Judah between 605 and 586 BC.

Jeremiah 50:17–20

Another poetic section expresses sorrow for Israel's hardships and promises future recovery.

Jeremiah 50:18–19

- Therefore: This word introduces two divine decrees. The first decree condemned Babylon to complete destruction, like the punishment the Lord gave Assyria (Nahum 3). Assyria fell in 612 BC; Babylon fell in 539 BC.
- I will return Israel: The second divine decree promises to restore Israel, specifically the people of the northern tribes, whose land was defined by the mentioned landmarks.
- Carmel is a mountain range near the Mediterranean Sea in the northwestern corner of Israel.
- Bashan was a region in the highlands east of the Sea of Galilee.
- The tribe of Ephraim lived in the hill country in central Israel west of the Jordan River.
- Gilead was a highland area on the east side of the Jordan River, opposite Ephraim.

Jeremiah 50:20

The Lord would forgive the remaining people from Israel and Judah. They would seek the Lord as they returned to their homeland (Jeremiah 50:4–5; see chapters 31, 33).

Jeremiah 50:21

- The judgments against Babylon continue. The divine Judge is also shown as the leader of the armies. The Persians were the Lord's warriors against Babylon, just as Babylon had been his warriors against Judah (Jeremiah 25:9).
- Merathaim (meaning double rebellion) refers to the southern part of the Tigris and Euphrates river valley. Pekod (meaning punishment) refers to a people living on the eastern side of the same valley. These people were Babylonian.
- devote them to destruction: See Leviticus 27:28–29; Joshua 6:21; 1 Samuel 15:3.

Jeremiah 50:28

The exiles returning to Jerusalem could reassure those who stayed behind. They could say that God had punished the enemy as promised and that Israel's restoration was starting.

Jeremiah 50:29–30

Skilled archers would kill the Babylonian soldiers, just as those soldiers had killed others in battle. This was the Lord's way of judging the ruthless empire builders who had defied the one true God by worshiping other gods (Jeremiah 50:38).

Jeremiah 50:31–32

Due to the Lord's command, the proud Babylonian Empire would never again become a powerful force in the world.

Jeremiah 50:33–34

The people of Israel and Judah had suffered a lot. The Lord's redemption would protect them and give them peace in Israel. God is strong and can redeem just as he can punish.

Jeremiah 50:35–38

- Babylon would face the same violence it had inflicted on others. The same accusations were made against Babylon as against Israel, Judah, Egypt, and their neighbors. They all worshiped idols instead of the one true God.
- The sword of destruction refers to the Persian army.

Jeremiah 50:38

The Euphrates River flowed through Babylon, supplying water to the city. The Persians reportedly diverted the river during a siege. They dug a canal around the city walls and attacked through the dry riverbed.

Jeremiah 50:39–40

Babylon's destruction would be complete, like the total ruin of Sodom and Gomorrah (Genesis 19:24–25).

Jeremiah 50:43

The Babylonians would feel the same fear that their victims had felt (compare Jeremiah 6:22–23).

Jeremiah 50:44–46

These verses are similar to Jeremiah 49:19–21, but they mention Babylon instead of Edom.

Jeremiah 51:1–2

The Lord chose Persia, led by Cyrus, to destroy Babylon in 539 BC.

Jeremiah 51:3–4

- God acted as a commander and instructed the destroyer to eliminate the Babylonians.
- devote…to destruction: See Leviticus 27:28–29; 1 Samuel 15:3.

Jeremiah 51:5

Even though the Israelites had sinned against the Holy One, he remained their God and planned to save them.

Jeremiah 51:6

The Israelites were urged to leave Babylon at the right time to avoid the Lord's punishment against Babylon (compare Jeremiah 50:8).

Jeremiah 51:7

- Babylon was like a gold cup, a symbol of great power and wealth. The Lord used it to rule every nation in the ancient Near East.
- The nations drank her wine: All those nations suffered greatly under Babylon's control.

Jeremiah 51:8

Jeremiah predicted the fall of the Babylonian Empire. Even though the Lord was delivering justice, people needed to mourn the event.

Jeremiah 51:9–10

Nothing could save Babylon; her punishment was immense. After Babylon fell, the exiles would return home. There, they could share stories of God's wonderful acts for them.

Jeremiah 51:11–12

The kings of the Medes included Cyrus. He marched against Babylon and overthrew it in 539 BC.

Jeremiah 51:15–16

God, as the Creator and preserver of everything, controls the storm with its thunder, rain, lightning, and wind, not Baal. The Lord can use these forces whenever He wants.

Jeremiah 51:15–19

This song of praise highlights the Lord's uniqueness and greatness. It compares the true God with the emptiness of idols.

Jeremiah 51:20

You: The Lord chose and empowered King Cyrus of Persia to destroy the Babylonian Empire.

Jeremiah 51:27–28

- Ararat was a mountainous region north of Babylon.
- Ashkenaz was Noah's great-grandson through Japheth and Gomer (Genesis 10:2–3). His descendants likely lived in Ararat, as did the people of Minni, who are otherwise unknown.

Jeremiah 51:29–30

The fall of Babylon occurred just as the Lord had planned. The Babylonian soldiers lost their will to fight, and the Persian invaders quickly entered the city.

Jeremiah 51:31

The king was Nabonidus. At that time, he was in Borsippa, north of Babylon. His son, Belshazzar, was the regent in Babylon. See Daniel 5:1–30.

Jeremiah 51:33

The city's wealth was like wheat on a threshing floor. Looting Babylon was like gathering a harvest.

Jeremiah 51:35

May the violence done to me and to my flesh be upon Babylon: See "Prayers for Vengeance" Theme Note.

Jeremiah 51:36

I will plead your case: In response to the people's request (Jeremiah 51:35), the Lord will bring Babylon to justice for its cruel sins.

Jeremiah 51:37

The looting and damage to the city's structures would make visitors feel contempt instead of awe.

Jeremiah 51:38–40

The Lord announced he would use wine to change the lion, which once terrorized and destroyed nations (Jeremiah 5:6; 25:38; 49:19), into a lamb that is easy to control. Wine as a tool of wrath was usually symbolic (Jeremiah 25:15–29), but here it was real (see Daniel 5).

Jeremiah 51:42

The sea represents the armies that attacked Babylon. The crashing waves symbolize the assault on the city.

Jeremiah 51:44

The defeat of Babylon's main god, Bel, was a huge disaster for the city. People would take away the idol's rich decorations, revealing its supposed power as a big lie.

Jeremiah 51:45

As the Lord described the terrors of his angry judgment against Babylon, he directed his people to their homeland to assure them of their safety.

Jeremiah 51:45–53

The Lord cared about the spiritual and physical health of the Jewish exiles in Babylon. Their political situation was dangerous. The Lord promised a future where the exiles would be saved from shame and return joyfully to their own land.

Jeremiah 51:46

violence: As an enemy army approached Babylon, the city's leaders blamed each other. Intense infighting was tearing Babylon apart.

Jeremiah 51:47–48

The Lord's punishment of Babylon would make the heavens and earth rejoice because it shows God's justice.

Jeremiah 51:49–50

Babylon would face a punishment as harsh as the cruelty it inflicted on the Israelites and other nations.

Jeremiah 51:51

The exiled people felt deep shame and disgrace for their past sins. The Babylonians defiled the Lord's Temple when they destroyed it in 586 BC.

Jeremiah 51:52

Therefore: The Lord agreed that their past was shameful, but he gave them hope for the future when Babylon's power would be broken.

Jeremiah 51:53

Babylon's walls could not save it. The city would definitely be looted because the Lord had declared their punishment.

Jeremiah 51:54

When Babylon fell, the noise of battle was overwhelming. People screamed and yelled, soldiers shouted battle cries, and boulders crashed as walls fell.

Jeremiah 51:55–56

- The destruction of Babylon was not an accident. The Lord controlled it and would make it happen.
- The sound (Jeremiah 51:54) would turn into the silence of death. The invading army would kill or capture the Babylonian soldiers, and the people would flee into the countryside.

Jeremiah 51:57

Belshazzar, the city's ruler, and his officers had a feast where they drank too much; it ended in their deaths (Daniel 5).

Jeremiah 51:59

King Zedekiah traveled to Babylon to build trust with Nebuchadnezzar. During this visit, Zedekiah likely swore an oath of loyalty to the Babylonian king (2 Chronicles 36:13).

Jeremiah 51:59–64

Just as Babylon destroyed Jerusalem, this great kingdom would also be destroyed. This passage contains a message sent to Babylon seven years before Jerusalem fell.

Jeremiah 51:63–64

Casting (throwing) the scroll into the Euphrates River symbolized the permanent destruction of Babylon.

Jeremiah 52:1–34

This chapter retells the story from 2 Kings 24:18–25:30, describing Jerusalem's last month, with some added details and changes. Repeating this passage highlights Jeremiah's honesty as a true prophet of God. Everything Jeremiah predicted about the city's destruction and the end of Judah's kingdom happened. Similarly, his predictions about the Exile, the hardships of the survivors in Babylon, and their return also came true.

Jeremiah 52:9

Riblah, which Jeremiah noted as being in the land of Hamath (see Jeremiah 39:5), was several hundred miles north of Jerusalem.

Jeremiah 52:10

He also killed all the officials of Judah at Riblah: This adds to the story in 2 Kings 25:7. While the soldiers abandoned Zedekiah as they fled to Jericho (Jeremiah 52:8), the officials stayed with him.

Jeremiah 52:11

The last sentence of the verse is an addition to the text of 2 Kings 25.

Jeremiah 52:12

On the tenth day of the fifth month: This date is three days later than the one in 2 Kings 25:8. The reason for this difference is unknown.

Jeremiah 52:12–21

- This section provides details not in 2 Kings 25. The Babylonians took great wealth by stealing all the precious metals from the Temple before burning it.
- The Babylonian looters broke large metal items into pieces to load them onto wagons and transport them.
- Each pillar was eighteen cubits tall and twelve cubits in circumference; each was hollow, four fingers thick: These words are added to the 2 Kings 25 text.

Jeremiah 52:13

He burned down the house of the LORD: The Temple was mainly stone, but cedar beams were between the stones. Cedar panels covered the walls, and cypress planks were on the floors. Wood was also used for window frames and doors (see 1 Kings 6). All this wood burned.

Jeremiah 52:15

some of the poorest people: Jeremiah included this phrase (see 2 Kings 25:11) and replaced "population" with "craftsmen."

Jeremiah 52:17–23

This section provides a more detailed list of Temple furnishings than 1 Kings 6:1–38.

Jeremiah 52:21

Jeremiah included the phrase and twelve cubits in circumference in the last sentence (see 2 Kings 25:17).

Jeremiah 52:23

Jeremiah included this verse, which is not in 2 Kings 25 (see study note on Jeremiah 52:1–34).

Jeremiah 52:25

seven: The parallel in 2 Kings 25:18 says "five."

Jeremiah 52:28

The account in 2 Kings 24:12–14 says this event happened in Nebuchadnezzar's eighth year. This differ-

ence shows two ancient Near Eastern ways of counting a king's reign. In 2 Kings, the year Nebuchadnezzar became king is considered his first year. Jeremiah seems to count the first full year as Nebuchadnezzar's first year.

Jeremiah 52:28–30

The numbers in these verses add to the information in 2 Kings 24:14–16 about the exile in 597 BC. The deportation in Jeremiah 52:30 is not mentioned elsewhere in the Bible. It was likely a Babylonian response to Gedaliah's murder (Jeremiah 41:1–3). This suggests that the person or people who made this adaptation lived after 581 BC, probably in Babylon.

Jeremiah 52:29

The eighteenth year of Nebuchadnezzar was 586 BC, the year when Jerusalem was destroyed.

Jeremiah 52:31–34

- This paragraph repeats 2 Kings 25:27–30. It shows how Jeremiah's prediction about Jehoiachin's future comes true (see Jeremiah 22:24–30).
- Evil-merodach ruled Babylon from 561 to 560 BC. Inscriptions found in a basement near Babylon's Ishtar Gate mention food rations given to Jehoiachin and his family.